adjacent tree, oppressed by heat and perspiring profusely. The gentle breeze that blew, shaking the leaves of the tree, cooled him and removed the drops of sweat from his body. Tārā, in the meantime, finished her dinner and retiring to her own room, did not find her husband there. She prepared betels, took some of them herself, and taking some in her hand, began to look for him in every part of the house. While, coming out of the house, she looked around, she found him resting beneath the shade of a tree. She then went up there and said, "Lo! how long have I been seeking for you with betels in my hand and having left me alone, you are staying here, gazing at the sky! what default of mine are you pondering over and what has made me guilty in your eyes? Pray tell me, whose love has turned you mad? But hang me first before anything else."

"What do you mean, Tārā, by all this? Have you gone mad? You are the very ribs of my breast—the collyrium-paint of my eyes. There is sweet drinking water, close beneath my lips, and shall I drink the cup of hemlock, rejecting that ambrosial draught?"

"Tell me, please, what wonder in the sky has caught your vision and what thought has kept you gazing heavenwards?"

"Yes, I am telling you, Tārā, what has kept my eyes fixed towards the sky. I mean to catch the Harikal birds by spreading a trap. Twelve species of birds, during the twelve months of the year, build their nests and roost upon the boughs of this tree. I have conceived to-day a longing for the sweet flesh of Harikal birds."

"I cannot quite understand you; my wit fails me. But I am burning within, with an intense desire—I know not how it will be satisfied. If you had a mind to taste the flesh of Harikal birds, why did you not tell me that?

I might have given you necessary instructions about the contrivance of catching the birds. Go to my father's house and tell him, "I want Tārāmani's [1] bow and missiles before night-fall." Vashu forthwith left for his father-in-law's house, anxious for securing the Harikal birds. Tārāmani here sat in the house, constructing arrows to shoot at the birds. She also made a score of earthen bullets; she looked up, at intervals, towards the nest of Harikal birds.

"Come, O Tārā, make haste and take these missiles of yours. But who will discharge them?"

"My bow and missiles I will wield. Will you be satisfied if I can give you those Harikal birds,—yes, a good number of them?"

"Yes, yes, prove your skill by acts. Just kill two of them first. Give me four daily, afterwards, if you can."

Tārā discharged two bullets at a shot and two Harikal birds were struck down and fell, screaming and writhing on earth.

"Bravo," exclaimed Vashu, "Expert indeed you are! Two birds at one shot!"

Tārā said, "Four shots are sometimes discharged from this quadruple-stringed bow; and five animals are sometimes struck down with a single missile. Two Kochas, Daru and Sumaru, lived in my father's house. Hundreds of unruly animals were sent to Death's region by means of their arrows and missiles. They were my teachers in archery and I have learnt much from them. Even if a hundred enemies confront me, they cannot long hold their own before the volleys of Tārā's arrows."

At these words of Tārā, Vasu thought within himself, "How shall I carry on my trade before Māniktārā? My energy shrinks within me and I feel abashed before her

[1] Māniktārā is sometime endearingly called 'Tārā' and 'Tārāmaṇi.'

superior skill." Tārā beheld this and tenderly put this question, "Why, darling, do I find your lovely face so gloomy and pale? Have my words pained you any way?"

"No, Tārā," replied Vashu. "No sorrow do I feel at heart. But one thing I am hiding from your knowledge—which I dare not disclose."

Māniktārā came closer to Vashu and clasping his hands in her own, said, "If you keep it a secret from me, no more shall I take my meal. The matter will one day come to my knowledge, be it to-day or to-morrow. The household cannot run smoothly unless there is mutual understanding between you and me. So, my lord, tell me your secret. I am bound to obey you in all matters and consider myself to be your trusted servant. Why should you not take me into your confidence! Don't you consider me worthy of your trust?" Vashu said, "Who else, then, is to be trusted with my secrets? After meal, I shall make a full disclosure to you."

Tārā made a delicious preparation of fish-curry and Vashu relished it with good appetite. Finishing supper, both husband and wife entered their bed-chamber. There Vashu dug the earth of the floor and a wooden casket was exposed to their view. Māniktārā started at the find—the casket with its contents of gold mohurs—even as one starts in fright at the sight of a snake. She fixed her wonder-struck eyes upon her husband's face and asked, "Whence have you got this treasure?"

"That is what I am hesitating to tell you. I do not know what you will think of me if I tell you all; the disclosure may hurt your feeling.

"Our neighbour Kanu and his mother are indeed bound to me in deep affection—I regard Kanu as my brother, and his mother is verily my mother too. To

them indeed I owe my life. My mother was in abject poverty and lived by begging, till Kanu's mother came to her succour and our sufferings were over. Kanu became my constant associate and guide in all affairs. How many acts of theft have we committed in a sportive spirit! When we came of age and became strong in physique, we took to the game of robbery and thus have we amassed some fortune by committing violence on the persons of way-farers. Only for the last twenty or twenty-two days, I am not stirring out to carry on our felonious pursuit and have, besides, removed all plundered riches from the house—for fear of detection by you, Māniktārā."

Māniktārā said with a smile, "Is this the cause of your fear and hesitancy? Admit me, my lord, into your comradeship. The husband is a woman's all-in-all; implicit obedience to his will is the very essence of womanly virtues. Wherever the husband may live, be it in a lowly hut or at the foot of a tree, the wife should bear him company, even at the risk of her life. No sacrifice is too great, which a good wife should not undergo for her husband's sake; a husband should not be deserted, even when he treads on forbidden paths. Banish, my lord, all your fears and scruples; I shall be your partner, in every sphere of life."

These words of Tārā roused the drooping spirit of her husband. He then made a full and frank confession before Māniktārā.

"Kālu, the notorious thief of Khaiea, is my formidable enemy. I can, by no means, cope with him; even as a snake of the 'Dhora' species is powerless before the poisonous Sankhini (snake), so am I before this rogue. Many a defeat has he inflicted on me and has, only through

grace, spared my life. The next scene of his marauding operations will be Naterkhuti, whither he will start to-morrow, crossing the forest. My band will attack them near about the pond named "Rajdighi" and seize their ill-gotten wealth. So I am waiting for the opportune moment. But I am not without my anxiety. You will have to stay alone in the house. How shall I go away, leaving you unguarded in this lonely house?"

Tārā replied, "What is the meaning of all these foolish apprehensions? What is the harm if I have to stay alone? Rest assured, my lord, Tārā single-handed, will be a battalion herself,—she is a match for a hundred. Twenty trained wrestlers I can easily cope with."

Vashu was pleased with her words; his mind now became free from all anxieties and premonitions of danger. He opened the casket of ornaments and adorned his consort with them—which made her look like a fairy, descended on the earth from her etherial abode.

A husband's presence is like unto a lamp, illuminating a dark mansion. A husband is the very crest-jewel of a woman, even as the fabled gem on the hood of a serpent. To a good wife, he is like the blessing of eye-sight, vouchsafed to a blind man. He is indeed the honey of the honey-comb on the tree. The love of husband soothes the heart of the wife; nothing can make her happier than the affection of her lord. Tārā felt much satisfaction at having worn the ornaments. She gently touched the dust of her husband's feet, and for a time, merry conversation and blithe exchange of jokes went on between the happy pair.

Jamaitulla, the country-bard, now advises you all to retire to bed. (Ll. 1-136.)

(8)

The bandits, twenty in number, led by their two chiefs, started out stealthily on their wicked errand towards even-fall, when the lingering rays of the setting sun glistened over tree-tops. Vashu and Kanu, each took a dagger in his hand and their grim associates armed themselves with spears, clubs and shields. Reaching Palasbari, they reposed for a while. Kanu, pointing to the pond at some distance said to his comrades, "There you can see the pond of the "cowherd-chief," full of clear crystalline water. We shall throw the bodies of our enemies into it, cutting them to pieces. Fortunately for us, the rogue Kālu is off his guard today, and has not got any track of us ; besides, this being Thursday night (*Jummā bār*) the party will not pursue their usual avocation to-night." These and other topics kept the mirthful band engaged there. They spread a worn-out mat on one of the sides of the pond and seated themselves there. They took light refreshment, consisting of sugar, plantain and fried rice. They next drank from the neighbouring pond and felt refreshed. Then they resumed their seat on the mat and began to chew betels, when, on a sudden, the distant rattle of the wheels indicated the approach of a bullock-cart. Kanu whispered to his comrades, "There comes the treasure. Be alert, my freinds, ready to wield the clubs. Prepare your mind ; do not, my friends, slip out from the scene of action."

Kālu's men arrived straightway there, carrying bags of coins on their shoulders, escorted by mounted guards, who formed the frontal array. All on a sudden, heavy blows were struck at the legs of the horses and the riders, too, were, in no time, sent to Death's door, their heads

being cut off—their mouth stopped for ever. The six carriers of the purses were also quickly dispatched, their possessions being, as it were, spirited away. The six custodians of the sacks of coins lay dead in the neighbourhood of the pond.

Vashu accompanied Kanu to his house, where the booty was carried. A great hue and cry was raised, in the meantime, in the vicinity of the pond. On receipt of the news, Kālu rushed to the spot but missed Vashu there, who had made good his escape, snatching away the morsel, as it were, from his mouth. In presence of some fifty of his comrades, Kālu felt himself humiliated; he pursued the marauder and overtook him within a few paces. Five robust persons caught hold of Kanu, and Kālu, their chief, seated on the pavement of the bathing-ghat, proclaimed his order, "Here is the miscreant Kanu with his men. Bind him fast to the wooden post inside the boat. You must take care to bind them tight, their legs fettered by strong chords and the hands of two persons, twisted backwards and shackled together. Let the night pass away; when the day dawns, they will be hauled up for trial. We need not return home in this dark night; let us stay here. Those of us, who can find leisure, will, in the meantime, roast fowls and prepare *Khichuri*. Returning home, you must behead these scoundrels or drown them in the river near about the *Ganjer ghat*." Supper finished, Kālu and his gang fell fast asleep. Who knows what dire fate was awaiting the victims? (Ll. 1-42).

(9)

Vashu carried the sacks of coins to Kanu's house and made them over to Kanu's mother, addressing her as his foster-mother. The old woman said, "What have you done, my child? Leaving my Kanu at the mercy of

enemies, you have brought these purses to my house!" Vashu replied, "What makes you afraid, aunt? Kanu is not alone; my band is there. Kanu will come back presently with the rest and then you will be relieved of your apprehensions."

Just at this moment, four or five men of their party came up to the spot, their anxious look betraying their great concern. They delivered themselves thus, "What a melancholy news, brother Kanu, are we bearing to you? Kālu fell upon us, and took away Kanu, together with four or five of our men, bound in ropes. They have moored their boats at the 'canal-ghat,' guarded by á strong array of men. The next morning the rogue Kālu will return home."

Vashu, as he heard this, left the place, and going home, related all that had happened to Māniktārā. Vashu said, "Will you feel yourself secure at home, if you have to stay alone?"

"You need not be anxious on my account; sister Panchā has come."

Relieved by the news, Vashu rallied together his men and hurried towards Kālu's boat, determined to deliver his captive friend. Darkness had now dissipated and the sky was lit up with the silvery rays of the moon. Kālu was sleeping, surrounded by a strong body of guards, who were keeping watch during the night. Vashu, on arriving at the spot, paused and said, "It would be an act of rashness to jump at the point of enemies' weapons. I would rather keep myself concealed in the yonder bush and wait for an opportunity."

(Ll. 1-22.)

10

Tārā, in the meantime, tried to think out some device, whereby she could bring about Kanu's release.

This act alone would satisfy her as releasing her and her husband from the debt of gratitude they owed to Kanu's mother. While engaged with this thought, Tārā's face was suddenly lit up with a flash of joy. She went forthwith into her room and set about dressing Panchā, whom she adorned with ornaments of various colours. She then equipped herself with a bow and arrows and selected some of the picked men from amongst her husband's associates. Coming to the river-side, they got into a picturesque barge. They went past Kanu's house, which stood on the left-hand side of the river, and farther down the stream, at a short distance from the spot, Panchā attired herself as a dancing-girl and Māniktārā in a jovial spirit began to sing a tune in a musical voice. Panchā danced to the accompaniment of the jingle of her anklets and Tārā sang a merry tune; and thus with great pomp, the boat floated down the current, wafted along the ebb-tide. Kālu's house was seen at a distance; but no elderly member was at home at the time. So Kālu's son, Dulu, shouted out to them, "Ho, blithe dancers on the picturesque boat, who may you be? If you have no mind to court evil, give us all details about your whereabouts; remember this is Kālu's house."

At this invitation from Dulu, they moored their boat there; and although a Kazi was seen approaching from a distance on the river-bank, they gave the following false account about their party and their pursuits.

"On occasions, like this, we generally make merry by drink and dances; if, at this moment, we are fortunate enough to secure a lover, we lock him fast in deep embrace and entertain him with our dance. Now we have come to you. Give us some drink, come to the boat and fulfil the desires of our young hearts."

Dulu, the young rogue, jumped into the boat—a dupe to their coquettish charms. They steered the boat homewards, singing and dancing all the while. On reaching home, Tārā first made a display of the warmth of her feelings and provided, for him, a well-furnished bedding, spread out on a brand-new bedstead. But next to that, Dulu was in fetters, bound hand and foot and tied to a pillar. His release was made conditional upon Kanu being set free. If Kanu was to lose his head at Kālu's hands, Dulu, too, was to meet with a similar fate. (Ll. 1-32.)

INCOMPLETE.

SANTAL INSURRECTION

INTRODUCTION

TO

SANTAL INSURRECTION

This short ballad was collected from Suri by Babu Sivaratan Mitra and sent to me on the 8th of September, 1925.

The theme of the ballad, as the title suggests, is the rising of the Santal population, inhabiting the hilly frontier of western Bengal—which presented a great menace to the security of life and property among the people of the frontier districts of West Bengal about the middle of the last century.

A brief preliminary account as to what were the circumstances, leading to an armed insurrection on the part of the Santals may not be out of place here.

The Santals of Birbhum, a branch of the ancient race of aboriginal descent, live in small sequestered hamlets, where they procure a living by hunt, but not unoften follow the avocation of agriculturists by growing paddy and other indigenous crops. In the past they eyed the Hindu lowlanders with suspicion and distrust and shunned, as far as possible, all contact with them. They did not grudge, however, people of the blacksmith caste, dwelling in the outskirts of their villages, as the services of the latter were requisitioned for making arrow-heads and also for fashioning iron-ornaments for Santal women —a fact, to which reference is contained in the text (Ll. 17-18).

The neighbouring lowlanders were not immune from the marauding raids of these hillmen; the latter, after

having gathered in their winter-harvest, stirred out on their hunting excursions, in course of which they would often make a sudden descent upon the lowlying tracts and plunder and frighten away the people. Thus, for a long time, the mountaineers remained a terror to the western border of Bengal.

But an important change was wrought on their habits of life by the introduction, in 1790, of Lord Cornwallis' momentous legislation, known as the Permanent Settlement Act, by which the Government became pledge-bound not to make any further assessment of land-tax on reclaimed lands. This resulted in a wide extension of tillage, which made the capitalists seek the aid of labour. So the services of the sturdy Santal were much in demand for reclaiming waste land by clearing jungles and chasing away wild beasts. The Santals, too, earned an easier living by working as day-labourers; sometimes they were given small grants of land, where they settled down to peaceful habits, turning waste lands into cultivable fields.

But the growing numbers of these Santal immigrants who often turned into restless wandering bands, caused an alarm to the inhabitants of the slopes. To prevent them from relapsing into their old marauding habits, the Government raised a solid fencing of pillars to wall off the Santal territory from the lowland districts. But a vast stretch of land, intervening between the fencing and the actual boundary of the tract occupied by the Santals remained for some time unoccupied, as the low-landers dared not come too close to the enclosures of the Santal territory. Here the Santals flocked in overwhelming numbers, quitting their crowded mountain-home, and were soon blessed with a life of plenty and prosperity. In these fertile slopes, the Santals lived for

a considerable length of time, as peaceful neighbours of the lowland people.

But this state of affairs did not long continue. The money-making zeal of the Hindu shop-keepers and tradesmen tended to strain the tranquil relation existing between the two sections. The Santals were simple and straightforward, honest and scrupulous, the Hindu merchants were often found to be crafty and unscrupulous. The dishonourable Hindu merchants practised deception upon the unsuspecting Santals in numerous ways in their daily transactions. The Santals brought rice and other grains and clarified butter for sale, for which they got cloth, oil and salt in exchange. But false weights were used in measuring the Santal's supply. Gradually, however, the Santals came to realise that they were the dupes of the Hindu speculators. Their miseries were further accentuated by usury. Sometimes, after having exhausted their little harvest on festive occasions, the Santals were driven to the need of approaching the Hindu usurer, who gladly advanced them loans.

But this act of kindness practically bound them down to a state of serfdom. The Santals found it difficult to extricate themselves from the liabilities of their debts, and some day they were surprised to find that their kind benefactor had managed, without their knowledge, to obtain a decree against their persons. Thus usury, in a large number of cases, developed slavery. The Santal could not get redress in law courts; the protection of law was hardly of any avail to the ignorant Santal. The administration of the Santal territory was not beyond reproach. Mr. Hunter, in his "Annals of Rural Bengal," while criticising the cheap and practical mode of administration, obtaining in the Santal area, remarks, "In the administration of the Santal

settlement, everything that cost money without bringing in a tangible return was avoided."

The Central Government knew nothing of the grievances under which two millions of human people were groaning. The English Superintendent of the Santal territory was busy collecting revenue and took no pains to ascertain the grievances of the people, whom he was deputed to rule. The Divisional Commissioner, too, was approached without any result. This indifference on the part of the authorities upset the balance of mind of the rude mountaineers. They massed together under two Santal leaders, who were brothers and one of whom was probably Subha Babu, mentioned in the opening lines of the text. Emissaries were sent all over the Santal-world; and there was raised among the Santals a general expectation of some mighty event, for which they thought they were called upon to be prepared.

In a few days, a great expedition set out and moved down upon the plains; but so long as food lasted, the expedition retained the character of a peaceful procession. The original intention of the expedition, Mr. Hunter holds, had been to march on to Calcutta with a view to laying the tale of their grievance before the Governor-General. But the danger of undisciplined armed masses, with no provision for food, marching through prosperous cities and villages, soon manifested itself. The character of the expedition changed; slaughter of Hindu usurers, looting of shops and raiding the houses of well-to-do citizens followed in the wake. The local authorities were not at first alive to the gravity of the situation; on the other hand, they seemed to treat the matter lightly, disbelieving that an armed insurrection had really burst forth within their jurisdiction; and we find in the text harrowing details of the sufferings

which the blunder of the authorities entailed on the people.

The ballad-maker has given the route, which was followed by the rebellious band and localised the scenes of disturbance. Thus we find in the ballad that the Santals first mustered strong on the bank of the Maurakshi, whence they probably moved to a village, named Bāshkuli. Here they assassinated a money-lender, named Becharam in cold blood. Thence they proceeded towards Sadipur, having created a havoc among the innocent villagers on either side of their route. At Sadipur, they plundered the cloth-shops and then went to a place named Kapistak. From Kapistak, they moved on and burnt down, on the way, the police-station of Langul. They were proceeding towards the east, but on meeting a detachment of sepoys under a commander marching to meet them, the Santals changed their course and turned back towards the west. They stopped at the house of one Gayaram in a village named Pererpur. In the meantime, while engaged in their plundering raids, they found the Sepoys on the opposite bank of the Maurakshi. But neither army dared cross the river. The Santals were beating their drums and making merry on one bank of the river, but the Commander of the Sepoy army was keenly watching the situation from the other bank. All on a sudden, the Commander of the Sepoys ordered his army to beat a strategic retreat.

Unable to comprehend this strategic move, the undisciplined Santals jumped into the river, elate with a sense of their supposed victory, and crossed over to the other side. The Sepoys now turned back and opened firing; a havoc was thus created among the Santal rank. The news reached the Santal head-quarters and caused a general depression of spirit among the mountaineers.

But soon a re-inforcement of twelve thousand hillmen from the Rajmahal hills swelled their rank and, with renewed vigour, they marched on to the neighbouring villages and towns and perpetrated unnumbered atrocities there, details of which are given in the text.

Speedy measures were, however, subsequently taken to reduce the insurgents and peace was soon restored in the affected areas. Compared with what we have known about the Santals from a perusal of historical accounts, the ballad seems to have presented them rather in an unfavourable light. We have seen, however, in the text itself, how the half-armed and undisciplined Santals, quite innocent of military stratagem, were mowed down by the disciplined British troops. The Santals knew not how to surrender. They answered the call for surrender by volleys of arrows, which made their mighty opponents open firing, and thus the poor Santals perished to a man on this spot. Mr. Hunter has, in this connection, quoted the remark of an officer, who took an active part in putting down the insurrection. "It was," said the officer, "no war, but execution."

The ballad-maker subscribes himself as one Krishnadas Ray in the colophon; from the vividness of its descriptive details, the ballad seems to have been composed shortly after the rebellion had been quelled. "In 1262 B. S.," writes Krishnadas, "when the country was inundated by a great flood, innumerable men were slaughtered by the insurgents at Abdurpur." (Text, ll. 126). So the author's own statement brings the date of the insurrection to 1262 B. S., which corresponds to 1855 A.D.; and from this, we may conclude that the ballad was composed sometime towards the latter half of the nineteenth century.

The Ballad on the Santhal Insurrection.

Lend me thy ear, brethren. To thee, my worthy audience, I shall relate the narrative.

The Santhals are up in arms, rallied together at the command of their chief, Subha Babu. They are raising their battle-cry and gathering in thousands. The security of life is at stake. Any moment, they can invade the locality and plunder the citizens. Wailings of widows are rending the sky; a general consternation is being felt everywhere. Even utensils and other small articles of daily use are buried underground by the panic-stricken people, who are always apprehensive of a general raid. The Government, of course, are anxious to devise means for the defence of their realm. Relieved, to a certain extent, on getting correct information about the resources of the insurgents, the people are speaking to one another thus, "Do not run away, leaving behind your properties. Hold on to your home. There, the British soldiers are coming to our rescue, with their bayonets erect, girt in their martial cloak. Their guns are loaded and they are, besides, expert riders themselves."

"Just tell me where the rebels have pitched themselves," some one asks, to which another replies, "Oh, we have just seen them arrayed on the bank of the river Maurakshi, where they are lying in ambuscade, turning towards the east and parading their skill in archery by shooting arrows at trees. Quite a colony of blacksmiths are being maintained on their

staff (of armour-makers). Arrow-heads are being supplied on demand and weapons are made to order with a surprising promptness, lest the supply should run short. The rebels are tight—girt in their peculiar uniform, with strings of sacred thread hanging across their breast. They proclaim their approach by the beat of drums; they take delight in slaughtering and revel in meat and drink. Having crossed Bāshkuli, they have stepped into the village-area; and people, at their sight, are flying in hot haste. Somebody, in the meantime, was expressing his deep lament for having to leave behind the big pieces of cooked fish. "Fly away! what a catastrophe!" these were the words on every lip and there was raised in the locality a great hue and cry. The rebels have grown furious,—thirsty of human blood, after having slain Becharam, the money-lender. They set the courts of law at open defiance and over-throw all authority. They are keeping to the forest-track, and arriving at Sadipur, they have looted the cloth-shops. Having looted as many pieces of cloth as they desired, and having made bundles of those, they have departed thence, carrying those bundles on their shoulders. In the course of one night, the bundles have been briskly removed from the spot and they have arrived at Kāpistaka. The drums, which are beaten day and night, have become a regular nuisance. At mealtime, the children of the Santhals come thronging in batches, with these words on their lips, "Brethren, we will gain the kingdom for ourselves and make our fortunes."

After two days, they set fire to the police-station at Langul. On receipt of the report, the sepoys marched with their guns and met Darga Munshi on the way, who promptly retreated to the west in fright. The Munshi's

band stopped at the house of Gayāram at Gorerpu They next broke open the locks of all the rice-granaries and looted them ; and hungry as they were for having had no food for several days past, they held a sumptuous feast there.

At once a detachment of sepoys, equipped with their bayonets, arrived at the river-side, commanded by their captain. They studied the situation very carefully and postponed, for the time being, crossing the river Maurakshi. On the other side of the river, the opponents were ready with their bows and arrows, and other equipments, but the fight did not commence yet. The Santhals were beating their drums and dancing in merriment. Nobody would, for life, dare to cross the river at that point; there was danger on either side of the river. The captain held a lance in his hand and closely watched the situation. Calculating the numerical strength of the opponents, two of the commanders held a private consultation between them and ordered the sepoys to keep the guns ready for firing. After a time the *Hāoldar* asked the Subadar to bring him a telescope, which being very promptly supplied, he mounted an elephant, and taking his seat on the back of the animal, fitted the telescope to his eyes. He noticed, from a distance, that the Santhals were staying in bushes and thickets, occupying an area of two to three miles. "Beat a retreat" was the order issued by the Sahib, and he himself led the strategical retirement. The Santhals, at the sight, marched quick almost with the speed of the wind. Elate with a sense of their supposed victory, they jumped into the river and thousands of the Santhals swam over to the other side. Their only cry was, "Ho ! catch them and kill. To-day we will plunder the head-quarters of Suri and overthrow the

authority there. We will rush into the jail-compound, muster strong there and set the prisoners at liberty. Our Subha Babu will henceforward become our king. The Judge Sahib will be put to death and all authority will be snatched by our chief. We will break open the grog-shop, owned by Krishna Saha, and drink wine to our fill."

In the meantime, the order was shouted forth to the sepoys, "Ready quick. Take arms. No delay." Alas, the Santhals were now brought to bay by the stratagem of the sepoy-force. An un-organised tribe, without any military training and tactics, the Santhals could not apprehend this strategical move on the part of their mighty opponents. All on a sudden, they heard the order, "Fire" thundered out from the enemy's rank. Promptly did the sepoys hold their guns aloft and discharged fifty shots at a time. The bullets flew in all directions like shooting stars, striking the Santhals on their back and piercing them through. Those who survived took to their heels. The rank of the Santhals was thinned by the loss of eight score of lives. The Santhals fled from the field in hot haste, not even daring look behind, and arriving at the Salakh hill, reported the sad news of their defeat to their chief. The report caused a depression of spirit among the Santhals.

The next morning, they all assembled together,—a re-inforcement from the Rajmohul hills was added to their number, their numerical strength now increased to the figure twelve thousand. They were now past all fears of death, always ready to give battle, equipped with bows and arrows. They came as far as the bounds of the town-area and sounded the trumpets. The citizens began to flee in great confusion—all castes and ranks of the towns-people. The people of the milkman caste—the

Sadgopas—fled from the city, not forgetting, while flying away, to take away the pots of delicious preparations. Old and decrepit people struggled to effect their escape, supporting the weight of their body on their sticks. The Mussalmans and Fakeers, with grey beard, fled in great haste, with these words on their lips, "Oh Āllā! how sharp are their arrows! Oh thou great Pir of Truth, save us in this crisis. Alas, alas! we are going to lose our life and all. What a dire calamity has befallen us!" But the mother of one Kālu Sheikh was lamenting only because her hen was missing. Everybody was anxious to make his escape; so there was a great rush—a whole population was on the heels, deserting the city in great consternation.

In the mean-time, two thousand of the Santhals made a forcible entry into the palace of the local Raja. They crowded thick there and looted all the apartments, setting up a great uproar. The number of the victims, killed at their hands that day, exceeded two score and a half. After all this was done, the Santhals, in great exultation, sat there, sharpening their battle-axes. Subsequently they beheaded the bald-headed fellow at Lâujur. Next they marched on to Kumrabad and crowded the locality by their overwhelming numbers. This village, too, was devastated by fire. Granaries of rice, sesamum and other seeds were burnt down to ashes. Cows, buffaloes, goats and sheeps were burnt in hundreds in that great conflagration. Just as, in the days of yore, the monkey-hero Hanuman jumped from one house-top to another, burning down the city of Lankā, even so were the Santhals marching from one house to another, setting fire thereto. Sadhu Das, a native of that village, in company with four others, approached the District-Judge and made the following representation to him: "Our

lives are insecure. We do not know what steps your lordship is contemplating to take. My paternal homestead has been reduced to ashes, and my brother, too, has lost his life at their hands. So please devise means; punish the rebels and defend the subjects from the horrors. With battle-axes they are devastating the country, which will soon be reduced to a forest-realm." On hearing this, the sepoys held their guns over their shoulders and marched on to Kumrabad before daybreak.

Now the fight that took place there will take a long time to describe; besides my attempt to describe the same vividly is like the dwarf's venture to catch the moon. The rebels took their bows and discharged arrows. They had thousands of trained dogs with them.

The Santhals heard the Sahib shouting forth the command "Fire"; and thousands of their rank were shot dead at once. This put the Santhals to rout and they fled towards the west. Some twelve men were killed that day in the *Boragar*. What untold sufferings and indignities were inflicted on the people by the Santhals! Many a woman, who were *enceinte*, were delivered of child on the way. In this way the Santhals went about looting houses everywhere. What to speak of men, even gods like Gopal had to fly away from their presence! Borne on the head of the temple-priest, the deity fled in haste from the Bhandi-forest.

"Oh mother Kali of Birsingpur, how can I describe your glory? Krishnadas prays only for this, mother. Allow him a place at your feet. Take pity on me, mother, and in your infinite kindness, deliver me from the bondage of the world. In 1262 B.S. when the country was inundated by a great flood, innumerable men were slaughtered by the insurgents at Abdarpur."

Krishna Das Ray says, "The Santhals have achieved a deed. All that I have recounted before you, my audience, are true. Believe me, brethren, my account is not a creation of fancy. Now before we part, let us utter the name of God ; for our days are numbered."

THE END.

THE BALLAD OF NIZAM DACOIT.

PREFACE.

The ballad of Nizam dacoit was collected by Babu Asutosh Chowdhuri, one of our ballad-collectors, from several sources. The greater part was collected by Ashu Babu from a village-rhapsodist named Sadar Ali Gayen of Allah, a village within the jurisdiction of the Police Station of Boalkhali in Chittagong. Sadar Ali, like all other rustic minstrels, follows an agricultural avocation during a major portion of the year, devoting himself to singing songs of this nature in neighbouring localities in December, when he is free from field-work. The remaining part of the ballad was collected from a juggler named Matiar Rahaman.

This ballad is still extensively sung by the village-peasants of Chittagong and is very popular with the Muhammadans.

The date of composition and the name of its author are unknown. The original might have been composed in the fourteenth century or earlier, shortly after the death of Nizam, the robber. But evidently some changes were introduced into it by the rhapsodists of later times.

It has hardly any poetic value. But it should be remembered that the simple village-folk greatly enjoy this class of songs, sung in a melodious voice, accompanied by a chorus—the charm of which is accentuated by the sound of musical instruments. Thus the ballads, which show no intrinsic poetry merely as a piece of

literary production, do not lack in the pathos of emotional poetry, when sung by a trained band of singers, and I have heard that the ballad of Nizam, the robber, is much enjoyed by the masses of the countryside when it is sung.

I have already found it to be the case in regard to these ballads that if the topic is social or domestic, the ballad is often found to contain fine lyrical sentiments, enlivened by flashes of true poetry. But when it has for its subject a religious tale, it becomes full of miraculous legends, much on the lines of the well-known Maināmati songs. There is no difference in this respect between a Hindu and a Moslem tale. They bristle with accounts of supernatural and superhuman feats, full of mysticism and wild beliefs. It is borne out by history that there was a Mahomedan dacoit named Nizam and that he latterly became a true saint, after passing through great penances and austerities. But in the legend of all the saints of the world, the element of miracle is a dominant factor; and this is as true on the Northern shores of the Mediterranean as it is on the hilly tracts of Chittagong or other provinces of India. The ballad is important from the point of view that the legend bears affinity to many Hindu tales and shows human psychology working in the same manner in the East and the West, in the account of saints. This ballad holds before us an important phase of popular Moslem belief and we, as neighbours of our brethren professing Islam, ought to be interested in these legends and traditions. When a person, whether a Mahomedan or a Hindu, rises above the level of ordinary men and becomes a saint, he is claimed by all, irrespective of the faith which he might profess in his earlier days. He becomes a friend of the world, fully cosmopolitan in his

views; and many are the *Pirs* at whose *Darga* the Hindus offer their *puja* and similarly many are the *Sannyasis* amongst Hindus, who receive a tribute of worship in the hands of the Mahomedans.

It is a curious thing to observe in this ballad that the Muhammadan rustic had a great respect for the Hindu shrines, nay for the Hindu deities, in those days. In the prologue, evidently composed by a Mahomedan, he sings hymns in praise of some of the local Hindu shrines and even pays his tribute of worship to Rādhā Krishna and other Hindu deities. It is a well-known fact that there are still many Muhammadan singers in Bengal, whose avocation is to sing the song of Manasā Devi and even of Kāli. This respectful and sincere recognition of the Hindu gods and goddesses by the Mahomedan rustics of the countryside and the corresponding regard which the Hindus have always shown to Mahomedan *Pirs* and to their *Dargas*, once strengthened the bond of unity between the two communities and caused them to have a genuine regard for the feelings and sentiments of each other. I do not know why, but the Mollahs and orthodox Brahmins are now trying to create and widen a gulf which never existed, and which is so fatal to the cause of our country's welfare.

In the preliminary hymn, we find mention of the Bara Pir Sahib. The mosque of this worthy still exists in the village of Noapara on the Karnafuli, within the jurisdiction of the Police Station Ranjan in the district of Chittagong. This mosque has a great celebrity among the Mahomedans of Eastern Bengal. Pilgrims gather here in particular seasons to pay their respects to Bara Pir Sahib from the remotest parts of Chittagong, Noakhali, Mymensingh and Dacca.

Sheikh Farid is one of the great saints, mentioned in the ballad.

Only five miles to the north of the town of Chittagong, there is a village named Nasirabad within the jurisdiction of the Police Station Panchlish. Here the *Darga* of Sultan Bazed Bostami exists to this day. Close to it is a fountain of transparent waters, which gushes out from a rocky underground and goes by the name of "Farid's Spectacles."

The village Nizampur of Chittagong was, according to some, named after Nizam, the hero of this ballad. Chittagong is held sacred by Mahomedans owing to the fact that this district was a resort of twelve celebrated *Aulias* or Moslem Saints. Iban Ba Tuta, the celebrated Arab traveller, paid a visit to Chittagong in order to see the mosque of Pir Badar.

The meeting of Sheikh Farid with Nizam is described in a legendary tale, which has many points in common with the account of Vālmiki, who had originally been a robber, named Ratnakar and was latterly reclaimed by Nārada, the sage,—as given in the Rāmāyana by Krittivāsa. I will presently make extracts from the two legends and place them side by side in order to show this striking point of agreement.

"পুনঃ বলিলেন পাপ কর কার লাগি।
তোমার এ পাতকের কেহ আছে ভাগী ॥
মুনি বলে আমি যত লয়ে যাই ধন।
মাতা পিতা পত্নী আমি খাই চারিজন ॥
যেবা কিছু বেচি কিনি খাই চারি জনে।
আমার পাপের ভাগী সকলে এক্ষণে ॥
শুনিয়া হাসিয়া ব্রহ্মা কহিলেন তবে।
তোমার পাপের ভাগী তারা কেন হবে ॥

করিয়াছ যত পাপ আপনার কায়।
আপনি করিলে পাপ আপনার দায়॥

কৃত্তিবাসী রামায়ণ, আদিকাণ্ড।

* * * * *

ফকির কহিল—"তুমি কর এক কাম॥
ঘরে তোমার মা জননী স্তিরি পুত্র আছে।
এই টাকা লৈয়া তুমি যাও তারার কাছে॥
রুজি করিয়াছ টাকা অনেক মানুষ কাডি।
মাডিদি বানাইয়ে শরীল শেষে হৈব মাডি॥
ডাকাতি না করিও যে বুলি তোমার স্তরে।
এবে হস্তে ভালা হৈয়া থাক নিজের ঘরে"॥
এই কথা বলি ফকির হৈয়া গেল চুপ।
হেষ্ট মুখী রৈল ডাকাইত হইল বেকুব॥

নিজাম ডাকাইতের পালা, ৩য় অধ্যায়।

Now a word about the history of Nizamuddin Aulia. According to my friend, Maulavi Sahidulla, M.A., B.L., Lecturer, Dacca University, Nizamuddin flourished in the 13th century and was a native of Delhi. As a robber, he is said to have killed fifty-two men before he had met the celebrated saint Farid and latterly, after having undergone great austerities and penances, he killed the infamous Jabbar. He is said to have exclaimed যাঁহা বায়ান্ন তাঁহা তেপ্পান্ন—a phrase, which has since become a familiar adage in this country. There is this difference between the versions given by my friend and what we find in the ballad, that in the latter we find Nizam first meeting Farid after having killed innumerable men at the rate of ninety-nine men a day, whereas the number of Nizam's victims, as laid down by my friend, is only fifty-two.

But a story very much like the one described in this ballad and in the Krittivāsi Rāmāyana is also related of the saint Fariduddin, who flourished in the 13th century. An account of this is to be found in the "Tazkiratul Aulia."

It is difficult to ascertain whether Krittivāsa, who composed his Rāmāyana in the beginning of the 15th century, attributed a legend prevalent in his times, to Ratnākar (Vālmiki), having taken it from the legends related of the two Mahomedan saints, or it was an ancient legend about some forgotten saints of the past —the original source from which the Hindu and Moslem writers copied it and attributed to their own apostles.

I do not know how Nizam dacoit, who was born in Delhi, could be so popular in Chittagong that even the rustic people there have been singing his praises for long generations with such warmth of admiring devotion.

The description of Nizam, the robber, his awe-inspiring figure and great physical strength, have their parallel in Kenārām, the hero of the ballad of the same name, published in the 1st Volume of this work. One striking point of difference cannot, however, be ignored. Chandrāvati, the poetess, who described Kenārām, was the very soul of candour. She gave the story as she knew it, without trying in the least to heighten the glory of the saint, her father, by attributing to him any miraculous powers for effecting the reformation. Yet the simple pathos of her tale shows the great saintliness and spiritual power of Bangshi Dās and the sincere repentance and devotion of Kenārām in such a powerful way that no legends, full of miraculous tales, could so effectively produce an impression about the

power of faith, as her simple narration of facts, in her beautiful poetical style, has done.

Many traditions are related in Persian Literature about Nizamuddin Auliā. Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri relates a story showing the liberal views of the Auliā. On one occasion when he saw a large concourse of Hindu people reciting the name of Siva (Hara—Hara) on the bank of the Jumna, Nizam composed the couplet "Har Kaumarasth Rahe dini Okili Gahe" (Every nation has a straight path to heaven in their religion) upon which his disciple Amir Khasru replied by another couplet "Man Kibla a rasth kardam, bar simal-a-kaj kulahe" (The crooked turban of my Guru is my own straight path). This refers to the slanting turban which Nizam wore. There is a tradition to the effect that the prophetic curse of Nizam, incensed at the oppression of Sultan Muhammad Toghalak, reduced Toghalakabad into a desert inhabited by the savage Gujar tribe.[1]

The ballad of Nizam, the robber, was received by me on the 15th of July, 1925.

D. C. Sen.

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[1] From an article by Mr. Jadunath Sarkar, C.I.E., in the Anandabazar Patrika 15th Falgun, 1332 B.S.

The Ballad of Nizam Dacoit.

(1)

First of all, I bow down to the Supreme Deity, and secondly to (the same Omnipotent Being conceived as) the Creator; and thirdly to the benign Incarnation of Light. The Koran and other Scriptural texts I regard as revelations—the sacred utterances of the Lord himself.

When the Lord was engrossed in deep meditation, the luminous figure of Mahomet flashed before His mind's eye, and as He gazed and gazed upon the vision, He began to feel a certain softening of the heart. So out of love, He created the prophet Mahomet and sent him down to the earth as the very flower of the *Robikul* (the solar race). He next created the entire universe. Had there been no incarnation of Mahomet, there would not have been established the seat of God in all the three worlds.

All reverence to Abdulla and to Amina; salutations at the feet of her, who bore in the womb Mahomet (the deliverer) of the earth. All honour to the city of Mecca in the west and to the Mahomedan saints; and further west, I do reverence to the city of Medina—the burial place of our Rosul. Bibi Fatemah, daughter of Rosul, honoured of all, was called 'mother' by all excepting Ali.

In the north, I offer my tribute of respects to the Himalayas, beneath whose snowy heights lies the entire universe. I bow down to the rising sun in the east, and also to the shrine of Vrindāvana, together with Lord Krishna, the Eternal Lover of sweet Rādhā. I next do

reverence to the milky rivers and the ocean, dashing against the two shores, with sandy shoals in the middle. In all the four directions, I tender my respectful compliments to all the four sects of the Mussalmans. I pay my homage to Mother Earth below and to the heavens above. I bow down to Mother Isāmati in the village of Râunyâ and also to the mosque of the great Pir at Nawapara. I next make my *salaam* to the hill of Kurâlyâmura to the right and the mosque of Hirmai to the left. The great upholder of truth once passed through these tracts. The river Sankha is also sacred,—in the middle of which there are shoals, obstructing its course; so the stream seems to be crying for deliverence from the threatened silting up of its bed. Tendering my regards to all these sacred spots, I proceed onwards and arrive at Sita Ghat, where I offer my tribute of worshipful regards to that ideal of womanly virtues—Sītā Devi,—and also to her lord Raghunātha. But the worthiest object of my worship is my father and mother, to whom I owe this corporeal existence on earth. The ungrateful son, who speaks harsh words to his parents, is first allowed a peep into Heaven and then hurled down into eternal Hell, the horrors of which become thus glaringly presented to him. There the wretch is doomed to rot for ever, surrounded by hell-fire and to cry for deliverance in the agony of his soul.

Finally do I make my obeisance to my teacher and then begin, with your permission, my learned audience, to sing the ballad of Nizam dacoit. (Ll. 1-44.)

(2)

In the eastern hills lived Nizam, the dacoit. He roamed over those tracts, always on the look-out for

victims, whom he would dispatch on sight. Early in the morning the dacoit used to rise from his bed and proceed towards the *Dighar*-forest, sword in hand. He had a strong-built physique and a very dark complexion. His eyes were fiery, and red like the *Jabā*-flower. His hair was crisp, and beard and moustuche long. His arms and legs were like wooden pillars, built from the trees of the *Jarail*-species. The grip of his hands was verily like the tiger's paw, his neck being like unto a lion's. His gaze resembled that of a buffalo and his movements could be compared to an elephant's gait.

To the east of the *Digar*-forest, stands a steep hillock, surrounded by thick bamboo-groves and cane-bowers. Tigers and bears, elephants and boars roam over this tract. To the west stand small mounds, overgrown with straw; and between two such mounds, runs a narrow pass. At one extremity of the pass there is a big banian tree, beneath the shade of which Nizam takes his seat. When travellers are seen passing by that tree, the dacoit suddenly makes his appearance before them and snatches away all their possessions. If they do not easily consent to part with their riches, Nizam bursts into rage and terrorises them; and sometimes the heads of his poor victims are blown off. Thus innumerable innocent wayfarers lose their lives in the *Digar*-forest. (Ll. 1-24.)

(3)

There was a Muhammadan saint, named Shaik Farid. In the deep forest he lived in seclusion, absorbed in meditation. He would constantly mutter the sacred formulæ and his eyes knew not a wink of sleep. It so happened on an occasion, that as the Fakir sat steeped in contemplation, his mind was distressed by thinking about this pest of the forest, and by dint of his

meditative concentration, he knew at once that the robber killed every night about a hundred wayfarers, in a ruthless manner.

The next morning the Fakir rose, and after thinking a while, assumed the guise of an old man. He filled a bag with plenty of money and having placed the same across his shoulders, proceeded on his way. With an iron stick in his hand, the old man walked slowly, bent with age, his eyes fixed downwards. When he came near the entrance of the narrow pass, he heard from a distance the thundering voice of Nizam dacoit. The dacoit had his sword unsheathed, his eyes reddened with rage. Then did he approach the old man and accost him thus, "Hear me, old man; give me all the money you have with you, or you lose your head." The old man asked, "How much do you demand of me?" "Two hundred rupees paid," replied Nizam, "might save your life." The Fakir, on hearing this, put his hand into the bag, brought out the amount of two hundred rupees and made it over to the robber. When his first demand of two hundred rupees was promptly satisfied, the robber gazed at the Fakir's bag, which still seemed almost full. The dacoit paused a while and then made a further demand of five hundred rupees in the following words: "Be prompt in complying with my demand, or you die." Uttering this threat, he began to brandish his sword. So the Fakir counted another five hundred rupees and handed it over, with great promptness, to the robber. This demand, too, being satisfied, the dacoit gazed somewhat surprisingly at the bag, which remained even then as full as ever. This set him a-thinking and thus did the dacoit muse within himself, "No ordinary mortal this old man seems to be. No drain or diminution has been caused to the contents of the bag even after this rather

heavy payment. So he must be some Darwesh or Fakir." He then addressed the old man thus, "Hear me, old man; more money you must give me or your head will be dashed to pieces."

The Fakir, on hearing about this fresh demand, silently opened the bag and coins poured forth in profusion with a jingling noise. Very soon, quite a heap accumulated there, which looked as high as a small hill and Nizam saw this. The Fakir said to him, "Just do one thing. You have your mother, wife and children at home; go to them with this money. A vast wealth have you amassed by making slaughter of men your avocation in life. But this body of yours is composed of earth and into earth will it finally dissolve. So please do not pursue this sinful avocation any longer, I beseech you. Mend your ways from now and return home." With this exhortation the Fakir stopped. The dacoit felt somewhat abashed and hung down his head. A shiver went through Nizam's body, as if an earth quake shook the Digar forest.

Once again the Fakir smilingly remarked, "What benefit do you derive from the slaughter of men? How do you profit by this money? Why do you build up a structure of misdeeds for your future? By your murderous activities, you make yourself guilty before God. When the final crisis will come, nobody will share the evil."

Nizam looked heavenwards first and then towards the ground. He looked vacantly and it seemed as if he saw darkness all around. He stood there motionless, as if transfixed to the spot like one thunderstruck. His grip loosened and the sword dropped on the ground and Nizam, the dacoit, sat there, weeping in distress, supporting his head on his hands. Shedding profuse tears, the robber approached the Fakir and threw himself down at his feet.

"Thousands of people have I slain for the sake of money. But how is it that my heart breaks to-day, as I am proceeding to take this money? Countless murders have I perpetrated for the sake of money, incurring overwhelming demerits thereby. Plenty of money have I earned to-day, but my heart is sinking in dismay."

Nizam wept violently, incessant tears flowing down his cheek. Sheikh Farid drew him close to his breast and asked him in compassionate terms, "Why do you shed tears? You wanted money, which I have given you in plenty." The dacoit replied, "No more craving for money do I entertain now. Accept me as your slave; this is my only desire." (Ll. 1-78.)

(4)

Sheikh Farid took Nizam in his company and wanted him to carry the empty bag in his back. In course of their wanderings, they found themselves in the heart of a dense forest. Nizam looked around in a restless manner and the Fakir now thought of conducting him through a trial. So a plan was devised by the far-sighted Fakir; the stone of the hill was at once transformed into gold. Looking towards the ground below, while walking behind the Fakir, Nizam noticed lumps of gold. He thought that luck had become propitious. A golden hill had greeted his eyes to-day! So he gathered a fairly large quantity of gold and placed it inside the bag. The Fakir, however, though walking ahead, perceived everything, and turning round, noticed, with regret, that the bag was quite full. He then said, "What is there, Nizam, contained in the bag? Just show me the same." At these words of the Fakir, Nizam opened the bag. But what were the contents?

Gold no more, but all trinkets of no value! Shaik Farid demanded, "Oh, where is the gold?" to which stupefied Nizam replied, "gold has been transformed into stone." Then the Fakir said, "Just return home. For, what will you gain by following me?" The dacoit replied, "The world is an illusion and so I have stuck to your company for initiation at your hands into the life of a Fakir." The Fakir stood up and said, "Oh no! You are not meant for that. Robbery and saintliness are quite different things. A vast treasure you have amassed by the slaughter of men. Why, in an advanced career, should your choice fall upon the life of a Fakir? You still cherish in your heart a hankering after wealth. So it is useless professing your choice for Fakirhood." Nizam, as he heard this, burst into tears and threw himself at the feet of the Fakir. His eyes bathed in tears of remorse and he said at last, "No more, I take an oath before you, shall I entertain in my mind any greed for wealth. If you do not take pity on me, I will kill myself in your presence." So saying, the dacoit began to strike his breast against the rock. The rock was flooded with tears from his eyes and blood from the wound in his breast. Shaik Farid hastened there and clasped him in his breast. The Fakir then said, "You have your mother, children and wife at home, all in anxious eagerness, looking for the moment of your return." Nizam said, "No, I must not think of them any longer. Certainly they will not share the evils that will befall me as a sequel to my sinful career. Evil company has ruined me. Save me, father, by initiation into the life of a Fakir."

Shaik Farid, on hearing this, fixed his iron stick to the ground in that deep forest and thus addressed Nizam, "Hear me, Nizam, this is the stick of my

liking and I prize it much. I would only leave you the following instruction to-day. Hold your gaze steadfastly towards the tip of this stick. Go on reciting the sacred formula with undivided attention, taking no thought for food or sleep, with your eyes rivetted on the tip of the stick. When, after the lapse of twelve years, you will split the point of the stick, a fine creeper will come out therefrom and greet your eyes; and on the very day of this occurrence, I shall make my appearance before you. So saying, the Fakir paced a few steps aimlessly and then went about his own business.

The forest was deep, infested by boars and tigers; but Nizam did not mind anything else. He went on contemplating the sacred formula with a concentration that nothing could perturb. His wife and children were left at home, quite ignorant of what had happened to Nizam. In the meantime, a rumour came floating to their ears that Nizam had been devoured by a tiger.

Six long years rolled by. A very wonderful incident happened in the meantime in the kingdom of one *Jangli Patsah* (the chief of a hilly tribe). (Ll. 1-68.)

(5)

Jangli Patsah was the chief of a hilly tribe. He lived in happiness in his forest-dominion. Riches he possessed in super-abundance. He had a daughter born to him—a wonderful creation of beauty. Her face could only be compared to the full moon; her voice was sweet and musical, resembling the notes of a cuckoo, or some soft tune of Kānu's flute. Her whole frame was comely and bright. She had a very slender waist and her breasts were like the budding growth of the plantain-flower. She was a rare beauty, having

scarcely an equal in the world. Lāl Bai was the name given to her by her parents. She had just stepped into her youth and even now, the lustre of her person could scarcely be concealed by her cloth.

Now hear me, my learned audience, what an untoward incident took place in the kingdom of the *Patsah*.

The *Patsah* had a Vizier,—a very good man, held in great esteem. This Vizier had a son named Jabbar, who brought on a great evil by reason of his improper sentiment towards the daughter of the *Patsah*. Jabbar was a rogue and a scoundrel. He tried to think out some device whereby he could abduct the girl.

Being the son of the Vizier, Jabbar had a free access into the Patsah's harem, which he visited frequently. He had already conceived a passion for Lāl Bai, and to achieve his wicked end, he resorted to the following trick. One who is pierced at heart by the dart of the triple-lettered word *Pi-ri-ti* (love) becomes forgetful of his prestige and honour, caste and pedigree. The fruit of love, even if swallowed, does not appease one's hunger; this evil fruit has been sent down to earth by God for the trial of men with an appeal to senses.

It once so happened that in her harem Lāl Bai was training her female-parrot to speak in sweet accents of human speech. She was all alone there. Jabbar Mia seized the opportunity and hastened to the spot. Drawing near Lāl Bai, he caught her by the hand. Shocked at this unexpected incivility she cried out. Jabbar left her at once with a start and took to his heels. Lāl Bai's mother came there and found her daughter weeping. So she asked, "Ah, my Lali, how is it that the golden hue of your face has grown pale and lustreless? Lali replied with tears in her eyes, "The wicked Jabbar came and caught me by the hands, I know not why."

When the matter was reported to the *Patsah*, the Vizier was summoned to his presence. Addressing the Vizier, the *Patsah* said, "Your son Jabbar had the audacity to clasp the hands of my daughter. Bring him here in my presence without delay. I will have both his ears chopped off."

The Vizier flew into a rage, ablaze like a torch, and hied home. Jabbar had just finished his meal and put a betel into his mouth, when the Vizier reached home and seized him by the ears. He took off the shoes from his feet and struck Jabbar on his head. Jabbar fell down on earth and rolled about in pain. He had his ears chopped off at the Nawab's command; his father, the minister, had a broom, fastened to his neck. Subjected to these indignities, Jabbar made his escape from the country. Nobody knew whither he had gone. (Ll. 1-56.)

(6)

Let me now relate to you what happened next. Lāl Bai fell ill and was reduced to the state of bed-ridden prostration. She began to wither like a flower, dropped from its stock. Her mother's tears now became incessant. Lali—the image of gold—did not recover. Shedding her last tears before the near and dear ones, she passed away into heaven. Loud wailings rose up in the sky and rent the atmosphere. Her father wept violently, beating his breast with the hands; her mother, too, vented her unbearable grief by striking her breast against the earth and tearing off her hair. The female attendants and maids of the house retired to a corner and shed silent tears. The neighbours and kinsmen, too, shared in their piteous lament. The whole forest-dominion joined in the

mournful chorus of bewailings for the loss of that maidenly paragon of beauty.

Listen, then, my audience, to my account of what happened next. The last remains of that youthful figure were carried to an open space, where they were duly interred.

In the meantime, a horrible deed was going to be perpetrated by villainous Jabbar. He called one of his companions and after having held a consultation with him, came up to the burial ground during the night. There the wretch indulged in numerous wild thoughts, all of which cannot certainly be recounted here. His beastly propensities became kindled again. He became resolved to exhume the dead body and commit violence upon it for the satisfaction of his carnal desires. Planning thus, they began to dig the grave. Nizam came to learn about this. He faltered in the course of his recital of the sacred formula and suddenly rose up with a start. "A hundred victims, less only by one, used daily to lose their heads at my hands; but even those misdeeds of mine are surpassed in heinousness by this villainous outrage." Thus musing within himself, Nizam made up his mind and hastened to the spot with the iron stick in his hand. The rogues had, in the meantime, disinterred the body. Nizam first recoiled at the sight. But when the scoundrels were about to take off the sheet which covered the dead body, Nizam, the quondam dacoit, forgot himself. He took the iron stick in his hand, and for a time, sobriety of temper quitted him. He brandished the club and struck the two villains on their heads. The blow of the club rent their skulls and killed them on the spot.

Nizam now returned to his former place of worship. He fixed the stick to the ground and once again turned

his eyes towards the tip of the same. Now he came to see the twigs of a creeper issuing from inside the club. The Fakir, too, made his appearance at this stage. Nizam stood up and did reverence to the Fakir, and then said, "Pardon me, Fakir Sahib, once more have I sinned; I have added two more names to the list of persons, slain at my hands. Forgive me, Fakir Sahib; O forgive me, my preceptor." Shaikh Farid, as he heard this, held him in deep embrace and pressed a thousand kisses on his brow. The Fakir then said, "You have reduced the period of your penance from twelve to six years by killing that scoundrel. If you can achieve such noble deeds, surely you would be carried to heaven in a celestial car." (Ll. 1-51.)

(7)

Let me tell you, my worthy audience, what transpired next. Nizam, this time, followed the Fakir. After having travelled through the *Digar* forest, they arrived at the bank of a river. Sheikh Farid paused there for a while and then took off the cap from his head. Having floated the charmed cap in the river, the preceptor and the pupil easily crossed the stream through grace of God. On the other side of the river, behind the market-place, an old woman had a shop of sweet-meat. Delicious preparations of cakes of many varieties the old woman used to sell. She was endearingly called 'aunt' by the local people. Now Farid and Nizam reached there and the woman *salaamed* the Fakir. The Fakir addressed her thus, "Hear me, aunt, this is my friend Nizam, whom I wish to consign to your care. Two meals you will give him daily, in return for which, he will tend your cows. If he can win your praise by carefully

attending to his duties you may give him something more as his wages, but that would rest entirely on your own discretion." Saying this, the Fakir took leave of her. Nizam fell at the feet of his preceptor. The Fakir consoled him thus, "Do not fear, my child, you will surely have me by your side in times of need."

Nizam accepted service in the house of the woman. In the forenoon and in the afternoon, he grazed the herd in the neighbouring meadows. Indifferent to what passed around, he always looked distracted in mind; the neighbours took him to be crazy. He did not resent or cry, even if he was beaten. He drudged all day long without any sign of toil or fatigue and seemed almost insensible. Bearing patiently all sorts of harsh and abusive words, he would still devote himself, heart and soul, to the services of anybody who might demand them of him.

The old woman had a son, named Sundar. He was an exquisitely handsome lad, whose beauty put to shade even the lustre of the sun and the moon. Since the death of her husband the woman was rearing the child with all the warmth and tenderness of a mother's heart. The child was always jolly and cheerful at heart; the cowherd became his fast friend.

Now there lived a great Mahomedan Saint, named *Bara Pir Saha*, who was known for his great piety and spiritual attainments, for his unbounded compassion and wonderful self-possession. He had a great affection for the lad Sundar, whom he loved and caressed as if he were his own child. The house of the woman, who owned the shop, was graced by the presence of the Fakir, who came there frequently to see the child Sundar. Sundar was indeed a very fortunate child, as it was his personal attractions that brought the saint to his mother's

cottage, which became now a habitual resort of the Fakir.

One day the old woman called the cowherd Nizam to her and he appeared shortly, before her. She asked Nizam how much he would demand of her as his wages. Nizam replied, "No money do I want, mother. I have no attachment for matters terrestrial. My mind is like unto a dry sea, it craves for an abundance of water. I seek one favour of you, mother. The great Pir Saheb visits your house frequently; he is the prince of Saints and a hundred *salaams* do I make at his feet. My one desire is to sit at his feet and receive instructions from him. If you are propitious, mother, then alone will my desire be fulfilled." At these words of Nizam, the old woman asked him, "Whose son are you? Tell me all about your family and parentage." Nizam replied, "I am Nizam, the dacoit. Long years have I spent slaughtering people in the *Digar* forest."

The old woman was struck dumb at the reply. She had no words to utter, courage failed her for the moment. She began to shiver violently, as if she had a sudden attack of a malignant fever. What did then Nizam do? At once he threw himself at the woman's feet and exclaimed, "You are my foster-mother, and more respected than she who bore me in the womb. Many a sin have I committed in my life. Save me, mother; O, save me from those."

Just at this moment, the great Pir made his arrival and announced himself by a shout. The woman hurried there and made her *salaam* to the Fakir. The Pir said, "Where is Sundar? Bring him in my presence without delay, as I shall depart soon to-day." The woman replied with a smile, "He is laid down with

illness. Please come early next morning, when I shall arrange your meeting." The Pir then said, "Do not deceive me. Why do you object to my seeing him to-day?" She replied, "First promise me a boon; then I shall show you my darling." The Pir said, "What may your needs be, which make you a supplicant before me! Why this falsehood, then? And whence this hesitancy again?" The woman replied, "I have another son, whom you must admit as your disciple." The Fakir said, "Yes I may initiate him into the mysteries of spiritual life, if he has the inspiration of the Prophet at heart."

The woman then opened the door and pointed to Nizam, at which the Pir exclaimed, "Oh my God! he is the dacoit."

With folded palms did Nizam recite the sacred formula. The old woman then addressed the Pir thus, "A confirmed marauder, he has now become a real Fakir. Let me now relate to you the whole of his past history." The Pir said, "No need of that, I have heard of him from Sheikh Farid. Besides, Nizam dacoit has attained notoriety enough and is widely known." The old woman said, "Know for certain, my father, this Nizam is dearer to me than my own child Sundar." Now the Pir was in a mental see-saw as to whether or not he would admit an old dacoit into his discipleship. Thus vacillating, the Pir became somewhat restless and the utterance slipped out of his mouth, namely that, "Nizam's *father* is admitted into the ranks of an *âuliâ* (a mystic saint)." Not satisfied with that, the old woman said. "I beseech you, father; once admit that *Nizam* is an *âuliâ*." The great Pir Sahib, on hearing this, made an utterance to the effect that Nizam's *forefathers* up to the seventh degree

in ascent would be henceforward accepted as *áuliás* in heaven. Not even satisfied with that, the woman implored with tears, "No, that will not do. '*Niazm* is an *áuliá*' this you must utter." And the child Sundar, too, joined in his mother's prayer and imploringly clasped the hand of his beloved Pir. Just at this moment, Sheikh Farid, too, made his appearance and repeated what the other two had desired. So a triple alliance was formed and the request was pressed with their combined ardour,—which the Pir Sahib could no longer resist and thus, finally, came out of his lips the gracious pronouncement, "Nizam *himself* is an *áuliá*."

Scarcely had this declaration escaped the lips of the truthful Pir when Nizamuddin, who stood expectant by, melted into air. (Ll. 1-116.)

THE END.

ISHA KHAN MASHNADALI OF
JANGAL BARI

INTRODUCTION

Our sources of information.

Regarding Ishā Khan Mashnadali, the most authentic source of information is the famous Ain-i-Akbari itself. Abul Fazl states that Ishā Khan's father was killed in battle by Salim Khan and Taz Khan of Bengal, and his two sons, Ismile and Ishā were sold as slaves. They were subsequently traced by Kutubuddin, Ishā's uncle, to be living in Turan whence they were brought back to their native province, and Ishā Khan soon became the ruler of Bhati and had twelve great Zeminders dependent on him. Hence he is called by Abul Fazl 'Mazban Bháti'—the governor of Bháti. Ishā Khan gave endless trouble to the Imperialists.[1]

Dr. Wise, Civil Surgeon of Dacca, contributed an article to the Journal of the Asiatic Society of Bengal in 1874 A. D. (pp. 209-14) in which he gave us a mass of information about this chief, who finally settled at Jangal Bāri in the subdivision of Kishoregunj (Eastern Mymensingh) and became the founder of the famous Dewan-family of that place. In another article on Chand Ray and Kedar Ray of Vikrampur, published in the Journal of the Asiatic Society of Bengal for 1874 A. D. (No. 3, pp. 202-3), Dr. Wise gives us some further details about Ishā Khan. Mr. H. E. Stapleton, in his notes "on seven sixteenth century cannon" (J. A. S. B., pp. 367-75, for

[1] Ain-i-Akbari, Vol. I., p. 342, n.

1909), discussed some historical questions relating to the Dewan family and their ancestry.

In a work, called the Mashnad Ali Itihāsa, written in Bengali by Munshi Raj Chandra Ghosh and Pandit Kali Kumar Chakravarti at the instance of Dewan Sovandad Khan and Dewan Azimdad Khan, and published at Dacca in 1298 B. S. (1891 A. D.), the writers have tried to trace a full history of the Dewans from Kalidas Gazdani, the father of Ishā Khan. The two scholars had access to the State-papers, preserved in the archives of the Dewan family at Jangal Bari and consulted the historical works on the subject, written by European and Mahomedan historians and gave a connected narrative of the Dewan family there.

We have got numerous ballads, in which we find accounts of the exploits of Ishā Khan and details about his descendants. First of all, we have an old ballad, which was composed by an anonymous poet probably in the 18th century. This is the most important of the ballads, mentioned above. The second one we have got was written by Munshi Abdul Karim of Galachipa in the subdivision of Kishoregunj, Mymemsingh, about seventy-five years ago. It is a fanciful work on the historical accuracy of which little reliance can be placed. The third ballad, written by the same author, chiefly describes the incidents of the life of Dewan Mannower Khan, a grandson of Ishā Khan and incidentally refers to the latter. The fourth ballad, composed by an anonymous writer, evidently a Mahomedan, is entitled 'The Songs of Dewan Feroz Khan.' In this ballad some account is given of Ishā Khan, the ancestor of the hero of the tale. Besides these four ballads, there are many songs incidentally bearing on the life of Ishā Khan, sung by illiterate rustic folk of Eastern Bengal.

The discrepancies.

I am sorry to say that the accounts given in the ballads do not always agree. We must try to trace the real history of the sturdy chief of Jangal Bari, the hero of a hundred fights, from these conflicting accounts and from those, given by Mahomedan and Christian writers. In 1586 Ralph Fitch visited Sonargaon. He remarks, "The chief king of these countries is called Isa Kan and he is the chief of all other kings and is a great friend to the Christians." From the Ain-i-Akbari we gather that Ishā Khan successfully withstood the invasion of the Imperialist General Shāh Bāz Khan in 1585. We have an account of his valiant fight with Man Singh, and all these indicate to the great power that he had acquired over East Bengal in the latter part of the 16th century. The 'Ain' frequently calls him "The wealthy Zeminder of Bengal."

The description of Ishā Khan's expeditions, of his memorable fight for independence and of his romantic abduction of Sona Mani (Subhadrā) is more or less familiar to the people of Eastern Bengal and though tinged with the colourings of rustic imagination, they have an undoubted historical background. But it is the question of his ancestry that offers us a puzzling problem.

The identity of Soloman Khan with Soloman Kararani disproved.

When Dr. Wise wrote to the Dewan Sahebs of Jangal Bāri in 1874 A. D. for accounts of Ishā Khan, they supplied him with the information that Kalidas Gazdani, the father of Ishā Khan, married a daughter of Hussein Saha. But in the history of Jangal Bāri, the Dewans must have latterly altered this view; for their protégés, the authors, declared that Kalidas Gazdani had married a daughter of Ghyasuddin, who ruled in Bengal

* J. A. S B. of 1874, pp. 209.

from 1560 to 1663. I suppose, I have been able to find out the reasons for their change of views in this matter, but I shall dwell on the point later on.

From the various accounts, available to us about the ancestors of Ishā Khan, it seems to be an undisputed fact that Ishā Khan was a son of Kalidas Gazdani, who had accepted the Islamic creed and assumed the title of Soloman Khan. Not only do the Dewans themselves attest to this view of their ancestory, but the fact of an ancestor of the Rajput Chiefs coming from Baiswara in the district of Oudh and settling in Bengal, and of Kalidas Gazdani's marrying a daughter of the reigning Mahomedan monarch, has had corroboration in various outside evidences. Mr. Stapleton writes, "Mr. B. Buru, C. S., Deputy Commissioner of Gonda, to whom I referred the question of Kalidas Gazdani's ancestry, suggests that he was a Bais Rajput of Baiswara. This is curiously confirmed by the note given at the bottom of p. 1. of the Itihāsa (Mashnad Ali Itihāsa) সোলেমান খাঁর পূর্ব্বপুরুষগণের আদিনিবাস অযোধ্যা প্রদেশান্তর্গত বয়েস ওয়ারা রাজ্যে।" (J. A. S. B., Oct. 1919, p. 370).

The first ballad gives some further details on this point. It says that Raja Dhanaphat Singh of Baiswara was a friend and powerful ally of the Delhi Emperor of his time. And Bhagirath, a scion of his family, came to Bengal with the object of visiting the shrines; he was very warmly received by King Ghiasuddin of Bengal. Kalidas Gazdani was descended from Bhagirath and latterly became a Mahomedan convert and having married the third daughter of that monarch, ascended the throne after his death in 1563 under the name of Sulaiman Kararani.

The older tradition of the family was that Kalidas having turned a Mahomedan convert and assumed the title of Sulaiman Kararani married a daughter of Hussein

Shah, who ruled from 1493 to 1520 A. D. Hussein Shah was succeeded on the throne of Bengal by the following Pathan rulers—Nasarat Shah (1520-1534 A. D.), Ghias-uddin Muhammad Shah III (1534-1536 A. D.), Sher Shah (1536-1545 A. D.), Muhammad Shah Gazi (1545-1556), Bahadur Shah (1556-1560), Ghiasuddin Jalal Shah (1560-1563), Sulaiman Kararani (1563-1572). I have taken this table with slight alterations from Mr. H. Nelson Wright's catalogue of coins in the Indian Museum, which is a reliable work, based on numismatic evidence.

Now the tradition that Sulaiman Khan and the notorious Kālā-Pāhār were both of them sons-in-law of the same Mahomedan sovereign is largely extant in this country. Babu Doorga Churan Sanyal's Social History of Bengal, though it may not deserve the credit of a reliable history, embodies a vast mass of the legends and traditions, preserved in the genealogical works of the Varendra Brahmins. He says that Kālā-Pāhār married a daughter of Hussein Shah, and gives an interesting account of this marriage, which is a love-romance. Such instances are not rare in the history of conversion and Cupid is admittedly the most powerful ally of the missionaries in the history of all religions.

Now if, as alleged in the family history of the Dewans of Jangal Bāri, Kālāpāhār and Kalidas Gazdani married two daughters of the reigning Mahomedan monarch of the time and if the tradition of the Brahmins be true that it was a daughter of Hussein Shah whom the Kālā Pāhār married, it must follow that Kalidas Gazdani also married a daughter of the same king. This tradition was in existence also in the family of the Dewans. Or how should it be explained that when Dr. Wise asked for information about thier ancestry, the Dewans furnished

the information that Kalidas had married a daughter of Hussein Shah?

But when, later on, a history of the family—Mashnad Ali Itihasa—was written, the authors consulted various English and Mahomedan histories, and probably inspired by the motive of establishing the identity of Sulaiman Khan with Sulaiman Kararani and thus proving the Dewan family to be directly descended from an Emperor of Gaur, made a statement that Fatema Bibi was a daughter of Ibrahim Malikul-ulma, who had married the first daughter of Jalal Shah (J. A. S. B. for 1909, pp. 37) and that Kalidas Gazdani had married the third daughter of Jalal. Had they upheld the older tradition of Sulaiman's marrying a daughter of Hussain Shah, it would not have been possible to prove the identity of the hero with Sulaiman Kararani. It is, therefore, evident that the old tradition of the Dewan family was changed in order to ascribe to their ancestor the status of a King of Bengal. When a new aristocracy springs up, such attempts to connect it with some time-honoured royal line are often made by the court-parasites and friends of the family.

Now it is proved beyond doubt that Daud Khan was a son of Sulaiman Kararani. We find it proved by the coins (Wright's Catalogue, p. 182). We find it mentioned in the history of Pratapaditya, written by Ram Ram Basu in 1801. This treatise, its author writes, was based on an early sketch of Pratapaditya, written in Persian. Pratapaditya's father Vikramaditya was a minister of Daud Khan, and in the family records of this valorous hero of the 16th century, many interesting accounts are given about Daud Khan. If Daud Khan were a brother of Ishā Khan, it would certainly have been mentioned by Ram Ram Vasu.

And curiously enough we find it stated in the 'Ain' distinctly that after Daud Khan's death, his old mother threw herself as a supplicant of the mercy of Khan Jahan, who had captured and killed her son. Can it be believed that the old lady would have done this, if Ishā Khan were his son? The 'Ain' mentions the names of some of the close relations of Daud Khan, but there is no mention of Ishā Khan there. On the other hand, that famous history traces the ancestry of Ishā Khan, describes the death of his father and relates the circumstance of Ishā Khan being sold as a slave and living for a time in that humble capacity in Turan. The early career of Ishā Khan, from this account of the 'Ain,' seems to be obscure. How he gradually rose to power and wealth may be traced from another authentic source. The Rajmala of Tipperah gives the narrative of the Kings of Tipperah very faithfully from after the legendary period when their connection with Yayāti of the lunar race is sought to be established. The tale of this pre-historic period is no doubt mixed with fiction. But the court historians preserved authentic records of the later administration, and barring some short accounts, where they now and then tried to extol the monarchs wilfully by giving them victories over their enemies, which they did not win, the general treatment of the family-history is quite reliable. Perganna Sarail keeps afresh the memory of Ishā Khan's exploits and fights with the Imperialists. There is no doubt that Ishā Khan for a time was a general of the Tipperah Raj and sought to please Amar Manikya in various ways. I will, later on, give in this discourse, an abridged translation of the texts of the Rajmala bearing on Ishā Khan. It must, however, be admitted, for the sake of truth, that the court-parasites,

who wrote the book, probably made a wrong statement when they said that the title of Mashnad Ali was conferred on Ishā Khan by the Tipperah Raj. This might have been done evidently to pander to the vanity of the descendants of Amar Manikya under whose orders the latter part of the Rajmala was written. But in all other points, connected with the Moslem chief, the account of the book seems to be a reliable presentation of facts.

Now the family history of Jangal Bāri Dewans, as also the ballads, make no mention of the early career of Ishā Khan. These records bring him at once into prominence after the death of Sulaiman Kararani, as a warrior who fought against the Imperialists. His obscure and humble life is ingeniously brushed aside in order to present him in full glory from the very beginning. One of their objects for doing this may be also to shorten, by suppression of facts of Ishā Khan's youthful life, the distance of time, so that he could be represented as a son of Sulaiman Kararani. As we have already stated, the first ballad says that the ancestor of Kalidas Gazdāni was Dhanapat Sing, a Kshattriya Raja of Oudh; next it mentions that Raja Bhagirath, a descendant of Dhanapat settled in Bengal and that Kalidas Gazdani was a scion of his family. None of these later descendants is said to stand in the relation of father and son but mentioned as mere scions of a family, of which the great ancestor is Dhanapat. I believe these names to be historical; but the statement of the ballad-maker suggests that there were many names in the genealogy of the Baiswara Rajputs, left out from the list. In order, however, to make Kalidas Gazdani same as Sulaiman Kararani, he is made to be a minister of at least three Kings and still retain the youthful

attractions of his person so wonderfully well that the youngest daughter of the last King falls headlong in love with him. There is evidently a good deal of patchwork in all these, which shows that Sulaiman Khan was hurried down to the time of Sulaiman Kararani to become identical with him. The similarity in the two names was certainly a fact, of which advantage was taken by the manipulators.

That this alleged ancestry of the Dewans of Jangal Bāri from Sulaiman Kararani was a point, neither firmly established in the traditions of the family, nor in the popular mind, is evident from the circumstance that Abdul Karim, who wrote a ballad about Ishā Khan at the instance of some of the later Dewans, states that Sulaiman Khan (Kalidas Gazdani) had married a daughter of Baber, the founder of the Moghul dynasty. In his zeal to sing the praises of his illustrious sponsors and extol them as far as he could by a stretch of his rustic imagination, he describes how, on the death of Baber, Ishā Khan usurped the throne of Delhi at a public Durbar, held on the occasion of Humayun's accession and how the latter, struck dumb by fear and surprise at this conduct of his brother-in-law, made a compromise with him by according to him the first rank amongst his allies and Feudatory chiefs, assembled there. These statements are not more authentic than the Arabian Nights' Tales and are scarcely worthy of any serious notice.

Another weighty objection to our accepting Ishā Khan as a brother of Dāud is the fact that though Ishā Khan achieved the status of an independent King of Eastern Bengal, he still prided upon the title of Dewan, inherited from his ancestors and called himself Dewan Mashnad Ali. Had Dāud Khan been his brother, he would have equal

reasons for calling himself a Dewan, as all other members of the family, descended from Kalidas Gazdani, have chosen to call themselves. But "Dewan" Dāud Khan is unheard of. On the other hand, we find Dāud Khan mentioning his family-surname "Kararani" in the coins, whereas nowhere do we find Ishā Khan calling himself Kararani. Dāud Khan is not known as Ismail, except in the State-records of the Dewan family of a later period. Here the Ain's statement is in favour in our theory. The later chroniclers of the family give Dāud the name of Ismail to make him a brother of Ishā Khan and thus establish him as a scion of the Kararani family.

If we summarise the three different versions of Ishā Khan's ancestry, we find the following discrepancies. Dr. Wise states, on the authority of the information supplied by the Dewans, that the father of Ishā Khan married a daughter of Hussein Shah. The "Mashnad Ali Itihāsa," published at the cost of the Dewans, says, not long after, that Ishā Khan's father married a daughter of Ghiasuddin. And the Second ballad, alleged by its author Abdul Karim to have been written at the instance of some of the Dewans of his time, states that Ishā Khan's father married a daughter of Baber! Either all these three accounts should be discredited, or the first one believed, as it has some corroborative evidence to support it. The fact, however, remains proved that Kalidas Gazdani turned a Mahomedan, assuming the name of Sulaiman Khan and that he married the daughter of a ruling Mahomedan King. In this all the three accounts and other evidences agree.

Barring the question of ancestry, there is a general agreement as regards the episodes in the life of Ishā Khan, described in the "Itihāsa" and in the different versions of the ballads, though there are points in them, which

received some colouring in the hands of the various bards and historians. None of these accounts, however, as I have already stated, noted the incidents of the early career of Ishā Khan, which, on the authority of the "Ain" and the Rajmālā, remain as outstanding facts of unquestionable authenticity.

I will, here, give a brief account of Ishā Khan's adventures in Tipperah from the year 1578, when Amar Manikya was the ruling king of that place.

It seems, on his return from Turan to Bengal, Ishā Khan did not at once rise to celebrity. He seems to have gathered a force and settled in Pergana Sarail in the distruct of Tipperah. I will here pursue the narrative of his life in Tipperah, as given in the Rajmālā.

Amar Mānikya asked Subuddhi Nārāyan, a son of Harish Chandra, as to the number of coolies, supplied by each of his allies and tributary chiefs for excavating the "Amardighi," which he had undertaken to construct at Chouddagrām, on the west of the Udaipur Hills in Saka 1504 (1582 A. D.).

Subuddhi Nārāyan replied :—

"The Zeminderof Vikrampur, Chand Ray, has supplied us seven hundred men. These men are all hard-working and clever. The Vasu of Bāklā (Buckergunje) has sent seven hundred and the Zeminder of Bhowāl (Jaydevpur, Dacca) has supplied one thousand men. We have received five hundred men from Ashtagrām and another five hundred from Bāniāchung (Sylhet). We have got one thousand men from Raṇa-Bhowāl and *one thousand men have been supplied by Ishā Khan of Sarail.* We have got one thousand men from Balaram Sur of Bhulua (Noakhali)"....."We have thus secured 7,100 men from outside and these are engaged in excavating the tank. Some of these Rajas and Zeminders have supplied

men out of fear and others out of love and respect for the Tipperah-throne. All the twelve Zeminders have thus come forward to help us with men. But the Raja of Tarap (Sylhet) has refused our demand."

Amar Manikya was highly incensed at the conduct of the Raja of Tarap and sent an army, 22,000 strong, under prince Rajdhar, to subdue Fateh Khan, King of Tarap. The prince defeated and captured Soddhorām, the general of Tarap-Raja, with his son. They were put into a cage and sent to Udaypur. The Tipperah-army next proceeded to conquer the Pathan King of Sylhet (Tarap) *and Ishā Khan was placed at the head of the navy.* [1]

" At the command of king Amar Manikya, the Bengali soldiers *undertook the expedition under Ishā Khan.* They went ahead of the tide by the river Surma and reached Sylhet."

Then follows an animated description as to how the Afghan chief, Fateh Khan, was conquered by prince Rajdhar and Ishā Khan. The names of the Bengali generals, who fought under them, have been given with some details of their qualifications in the account. Fateh Khan surrendered himself and was brought to Udaypur on the 1st of Magh in Saka 1504 (about the middle of January, 1582). " The king publicly praised Ishā Khan for his valour and gave him a seat on the left side of his son-in-law, Dayāvant Narain," at a Durbar held to commemorate his victory.

Sometime after this an Amir of the Delhi Emperor (probably Shah Baz Khan) led an expedition into the very heart of Eastern Bengal and attacked Ishā Khan who seems to have planted himself firmly at Sarail and

[1] The italics are ours

the adjacent locality by this time. Ishā beat a retreat and sought the help of Amar Manikya at this crisis.

He consulted two generals of the Raja—Tāz Khan and Bāz Khan, as to how he could secure substantial help from the Tipperah Raja and was advised to apply to queen Amarāvati Devi for intercession in his behalf. "The King," they said, "was a devoted husband and listened to the counsel of his queen in all matters." Ishā Khan sent a petition to queen Amarāvati and addressed her as "Mother" in the letter. This sort of address to an Indian lady is sure to appeal to her tenderly and ensure sympathy for the supplicant. The queen, at the request of Ishā Khan, washed her breast with water and sent him a drop to drink, which the Muhammadan Chief did with all affection and respect. This act was tantamount to his sucking the breast of the queen in the manner of a child, and Ishā Khan was treated from this time as a foster-son of Amarāvati. Curiously Mr. Long in his abridged translation of the Rajmālā renders the Bengali passage in the following words :—

"He (Ishā Khan) also won the favour of the Rani who tested his sincerity by giving him the water with which she had washed her body. He drank it." [1] What a queer and monstrous idea! But a foreign writer may be excused for his mistake on a point like this. We wonder how a scholar like Babu Kailas Chandra Sinha could paraphrase the verse in the following rendering! "অমরমাণিক্যের রাজ্ঞীও ঈষা খাঁকে পাদোদক প্রেরণ করিয়া বলিয়া পাঠাইলেন," etc. He calls it the water in which the king's feet were washed. He was evidently afraid of referring to the breast of the queen, lest it should offend the delicate sense of decency of our educated countrymen, imbibed by them from the western people. This is, however, a

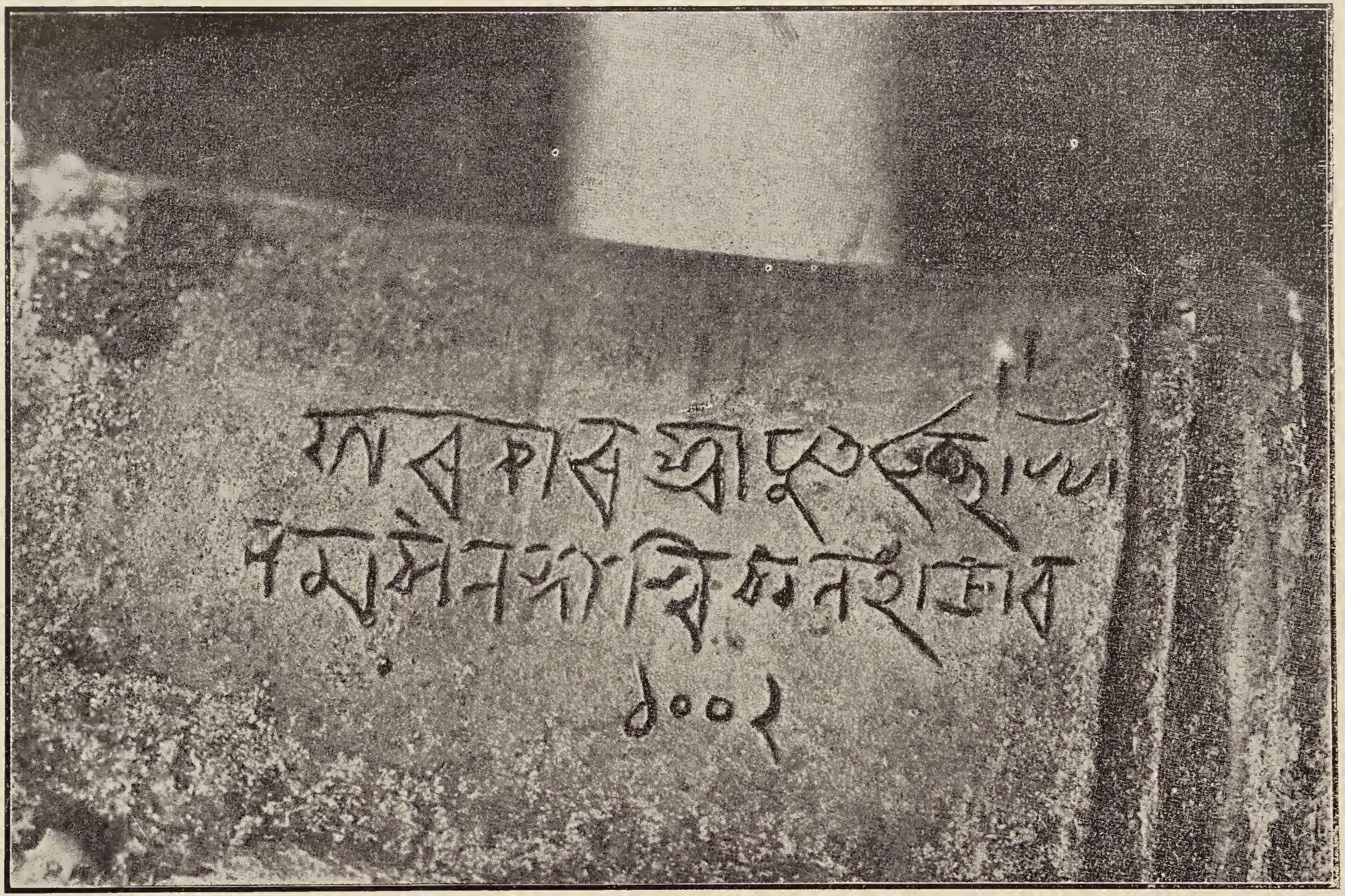
[1] Analysis of Rajmālā by Rev. J. Long, p. 16.

sacred convention with the Asiatic races and there is nothing unholy or indecent in referring to the mother's breast at least in the eyes of the Oriental people.

Ishā Khan thus succeeded in ingratiating himself into the confidence of Amar Manikya, who was already predisposed in his favour for his past services in the interest of the State. The king granted him fifty thousand soldiers. As soon as Ishā Khan reached Sarail with this army, the Delhi General retreated from the field without venturing an encounter. It is stated here that Ishā Khan got many tokens of royal favour from Tipperah; but when we find the author of Rajāmālā, mentioning in this connection, that the title of 'Machalandani' was conferred on Ishā Khan by Amar Manikya, we feel that the court-parasite was perhaps trying to humour a descendant of that Raja, at whose order the history was written. But here, also, we reserve our judgment for reasons stated in the foot-note.[1]

Ishā Khan was now the master of 52,000 soldiers, as we find in the account of Rajmālā. He probably conceived from this time the idea of establishing his independence in Bengal. He could not have possibly

[1] Curiously the fit title of Ishā Khan, inscribed on his gun is not "Mashnad Ali," but, barring the 1st letter, which cannot be deciphered (probably a mere scratch) and which Stapleton reads as ব with a sign of query, the word reads Masenandalwi (মসেনন্দাল্বি). The reading of this word by Mr. Stapleton as "বমসনদী ফি" is evidently incorrect. The word "মচলন্দানি" (the চ and স have similar sound in ordinary spoken Bengali and the ন, the last letter in the word, may have been confounded with ল by the Bengali copyist) seems very much similar to মসনন্দাল্বি of the gun. Is it the Bengali form of the word Mashnad Ali? That the title of Mashnad Ali was granted to Ishā Khan by Akbar, is not known, so far as I am aware, from any other source than the State-record of the Dewan family itself. The repeated attempts of the historians of Jangal Bāri to connect the Dewans with the emperors of Delhi in all matters make us view this point with some suspicion. What is the reason for their having obliterated all facts relating to Ishā Khan's dealings with Amar Manikya, the king of Tippera? It should be stated here that the Khilat, if it was conferred on Ishā Khan by Akbar, has not been preserved in the family.



A Cannon of Ishā Khan with inscription. P. 314



Laksman Hazra's Capital reduced to a swamp. P. 315

achieved this end, remaining in the district of Sarail, for there he could only hold the status of a Feudatory Chief under the Tipperah Raja. Besides some other developments took place at Sarail, which made his position there not a very enviable one. Prince Rajdhara in one of his hunting excursions, found Pergana Sarail as abounding with jungles—a resort of buffaloes, bears, tigers and antelopes. The game attracted him and crossing the Titāsh, he wandered through the 42 villages of the Pergana, placed in the midst of a great wilderness and conceived the idea of founding a country-house at Sarail, from which he could go out a-hunting and extend his dominions by cutting down the jungle (the Rajmālā, p. 193).

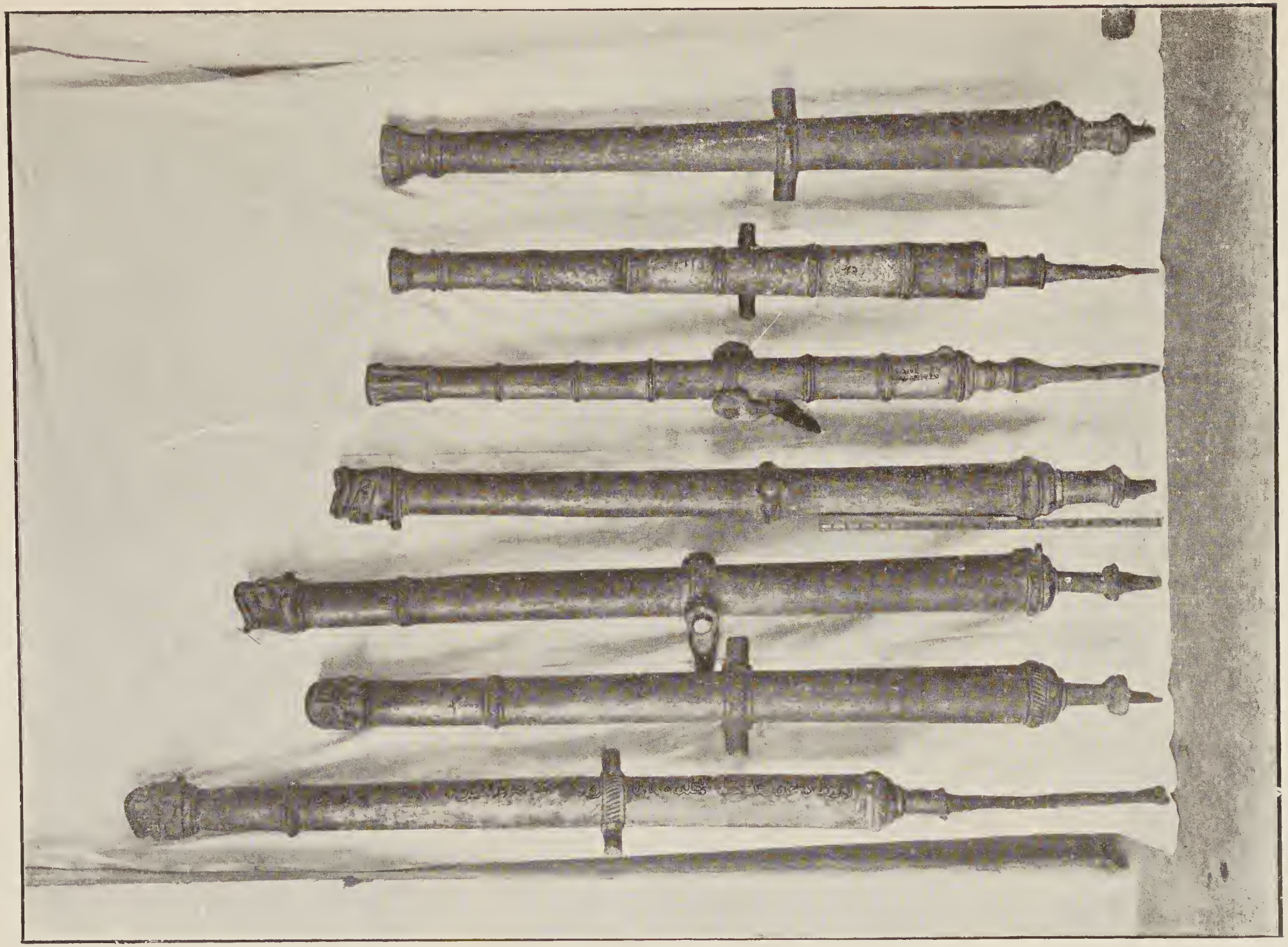
Shah Bāz Khan was, in the meantime, preparing himself for a fight to avenge himself upon Ishā Khan for the affront the latter had given him with the aid of the Tipperah Raja. Ishā Khan, now master of a great army, wanted to find a secure place where he could be safe from the hands of the Imperialists and extend his power by new conquests. The details of his fights with the Delhi army and of his flight from the field are given in some of these ballads. It was at this time (1585 A.D.) that the unfortunate Coch Rajas, the brothers, Ram Hazra and Lakshman Hazra, were suddenly attacked by Ishā during the night. They fled by means of a tunnel in the palace—the relics of which are still in existence. The capital of the Coch Rajas, the Jangal Bāri (the Forest-home) became the chief seat of Ishā Khan's family.

In the ballad of Dewan Mannowar Khan, a grandson of Ishā Khan, we have got a reference to the palace the former had built at Dacca. The place where the stately mansion once stood, is still called "Dewan

Bāg."[1] In the survey-map the place is called 'Mannowar Khaner Bāg.' It is situate dnear the junction of the Akātiā Khāl and Sitalākshyā, seven miles north-east of Narain-gunj. In the 'Dewan Bāg' seven brass cannon were discovered by some men, while excavating earth, some-time in February, 1909. Mr. S. E. Stinton, the then Magistrate of Dacca, made over the cannon to Mr. Stapleton for description. The latter has given a detailed account of these guns in the October number of the Journal of Asiatic Society Bengal, 1899. The first of these is tiger-mouthed and bears an inscription of Sher Shah, dated the 949 H. E. (1542 A. D.). The second, third and fourth are nearly of the same model and have tiger-heads on the top. This tiger may be taken as a symbol of Sher or tiger, in compliment to the King. The remaining three guns evidently belong to Ishā Khan. On the first of them is inscribed his name; the other two are of the same type. These seven cannon were undoubtedly the possessions of the Dewans. The inscription in Persian on the first gun shows that Sher Shah cast it in the year 1542; but it is noteworthy that at the other end of the gun, below the breech, is found, in Bengali, the word "Tarap Raja."

We have already found it, on the authority of the Rajmālā that Ishā Khan and prince Rajdhar led an expedition to Tarap and conquered the Pathan chief, Fateh Khan. This Fateh Khan must have secured Sher Shah's guns by inheritance or by force and when they became his property, he had, at least on one of them, the word "Tarap Raja" inscribed in Bengali, implying his present ownership. Sher Shah came from the northwest and hence his inscription was in Persian, the court-language

* 1. According to Dr. Wise, this garden-house coverred an area of 169 acres. See "Isha Khan Masnadali of Khizirpur". J. A. S. B. 1874. pp. 209-214.



Ishā Khan's Cannon. P. 316

of Delhi and other western provinces, occupied by the Mahomedans. But in Sylhet, Assam and Tipperah in Eastern Bengal, generally the court-language was Bengali during the 14th to 18th centuries, as is proved by the coins and copper-plate grants, issued by the rulers of these countries. This accounts for the fact that the fifth gun, bearing Ishā Khan's name, has its inscription in Bengali characters. We have thus found a sure clue as to how the four guns of Sher Shah came to the possession of Ishā Khan. Sher Shah was an Afghan and Fateh Khan of Tarap was also of the same tribe. So it is quite conceivable that Fateh Khan secured the guns of Sher Shah by direct inheritance or from some of his kinsmen. Ishā Khan obtained them by his victory over Fateh Khan. The remaining three guns belonged to Ishā Khan and no comment is necessary on them, except a historical point, involved in the date, inscribed in Bengali on one of them, to which I wish to draw attention. It is Hizra 1002 or 1593 A.D., the year when Man Sing was sent to conquer the redoubted chief of Jangal Bāri. It was evidently for the purpose of equipping himself for fighting with the Hindu General of Akbar that Ishā Khan cast some new guns and these three indicate the martial exigencies of the year.

Thus from the year 1578 when, as a landlord of some status, Ishā Khan sent one thousand men responding to a call from Amar Manikya to help in the excavation of the "Amar Dighi" near the Udeypur hills, down to the year 1593 when he fought battles with Man Sing and surrendered himself at Egara Sindur to the latter after a strenuous warfare, which evoked the admiration of Akbar and led him to order his release and confer a grant of twenty-two Perganas on him, we have a

connected narrative of Ishā Khan's life, gathered from different sources. The first part of his career was ignored by the bards and chroniclers, who were appointed to write the history of Jangal Bāri by some of the Dewans themselves. But, for the detailed account of the latter part of his life, we have enough material in those treatises and ballads, though the reader must always be cautious in accepting the accounts as correct in their details.

The State-records, and following these, Dr. Wise have declared that Kalidas Gazdani was convinced of the superiority of Islam by the learned lectures of the court-minister of the reigning Moslem King and renounced Hinduism in his sincere faith in the new creed. But the first ballad relates a romantic love-affair. As it is certain that he married a Moslem princess, the greater possibility is that he favoured Muhammadanism because he loved a Muhammadan princess. He was a Hindu of the orthodox type. He gave away every day an elephant, plated with gold, to Brahmins, for which he was called "Gazdāni" (of course the elephant was far from being life-size). We are not inclined to believe that such a devout Hindu, as he was, could give up his religion at once, listening to the discourses of a Mahomedan minister, who is not known to have been an inspired prophet. A greater probability lies in the other direction where the omnipotent deity, presiding over the heart of human beings, found an opportunity to aim his dart. The State-papers of Jangal Bāri have very solid reasons for giving this shape to the story. They would naturally try to suppress anything that might look like a family scandal, as in Indian homes these points are so delicate that a very slight matter often proves damaging to the honour

of a household. At the same time one point may be urged by way of discrediting the accounts of the ballad-makers that it is very usual with them to introduce a love-tale, wherever they find a margin or blank space in the body of the narrative, where they can conveniently manage to do it. With these remarks, I leave the readers to form their own judgments. The Dewans of Jangal Bāri once wielded great power over Eastern Bengal, but in spite of it, they were looked down upon by the genuine Mahomedan family, who had come from the north-west and settled there. In the ballad of Dewan Ferōz Khān, we find how a proposal of his marriage with a princess of Kella Tāzpur was indignantly rejected by her father Omar Khan. He called the Dewan family of Jangal Bāri *kafirs*, and infidels, guided by Hindu tastes and having Hindu blood running in their veins.

The name of Kedar Ray's daughter, as given in the ballad, is Subhadrā. She is, however, traditionally known among the Hindus by the name of Sonā or Sonāmani, which our writers sometimes turn into its Sanskritised form 'Swarnamayee.' It is not unlikely that amongst her own people, she was known by her more familiar pet-name of Sonā or Sonāmani, and when she entered the Mahomedan harem, she assumed her more dignified name Subhadrā. Difficulties have sometimes arisen in respect of the names of many of the personages, mentioned in these ballads. The popular ballads have sometimes given the more familiar names, quite different from those used in official documents. Amongst strangers, whom latterly Sonā adopted as her own, it was most natural for her to give up her undignified pet-name and use the classical word 'Subhadrā' instead. All accounts agree in stating

that the Mahomedan name she adopted was Niyāmat Jān.[1]

We do not find any mention of the sons of Subhadrā either in the 'Mashnad Ali Itihāsa' or in the genealogy, given of the Dewan family by Mr. Stapleton in his article. But the names of Adam and Birām are quite familiar in the literature of the ballads, dealing with the history of the Dewan family, mostly written by Mahomedans. We find a good many incidents of their lives described in these ballads. There seems to be no reason to doubt that Ishā Khan got two sons by the Hindu princess and that they were called Adam and Birām. Of course they were familiarly called by these names. They had certainly some dignified names, used in official records, to which we have not been able to get a clue. Babu Durgacharan Sanyal gives an account of Sonamani's (Subhadrā's) return to her father's home on the death of Ishā Khan and living an ascetic life, as an outcaste. He says that the Dewans of Haibatpur were descended from the sons of the Hindu Begum of Ishā Khan.[2] I do not know how far the statement is true.

Of course, the orthodox Mahomedan writers would not like the idea of tracing the descent of a noble Moslem family from a Hindu and hence it might be quite possible that some of them would try to obliterate all trace of a princess of Kayastha family from the genealogy of the Dewans. We all know that Jahangir was a son of Jodha Bāi and there were many

[1] We have recently come across a ballad evidently composed by a Muhammadan in which she is called Sonai and not Subhadra.

[2] Printed as Sahabatpur, but corrected in the author's own handwriting in the margin of the copy, presented to me, as Haibatpur.—*Sanyal's Social History of Bengal*, p. 443.

such cases in the aristocratic Muhammadan families of India. But an Emperor of Delhi could assimilate foreign elements in his home, and he was too high to be criticised. Besides, when a point was an undisputed fact of history, there was no help but to admit it. But in smaller communities, and where one could easily wipe away all signs of a foreign connection, it is not unlikely that such a thing should happen. A Mahomedan nobleman may be naturally looked down upon for being descended from a Hindu wife, by orthodox people amongst Muhammadans. In the face of the existing circumstances, however, there is no clue to discover if any of the numerous branches of the Dewan family has wilfully blotted out the name of the princess of Sripur from their genealogical accounts. We attach no importance to what Mr. Sanyal says about the Haibatpur branch being descended from her, as the writer gives no authority for his statement. Dr. Wise mentions that there is a curious custom in one of the branches of the Dewan family, settled at Harishpur in Tippera, that the eldest son of the Zaminder is always styled 'Thākur.' This merely proves the existence of a Hindu custom in the family. And it should be known that the title of Thākur is not confined in Bengal to the Brahmins alone; it is also found amongst the Kayasthas and some other high castes. I do not know if this title refers to any custom in the family of the abducted Hindu princess. The title may also imply that the particular line of the Dewan family, stationed in the Tippera Rāj, adopted the custom in imitation of the Tippera Rajas, whose eldest son inherits the Rāj and is called "Yubarāj" and the second son is called by the title "Thākur."

There is, however, another possibility, which I beg to suggest, in spite of its doubtful character, in the absence of any historical evidence.

It is a well-known fact that the residence of Ishā Khan at Baktiarpur was destroyed by the imperial troops under Shah Bāz Khan in 1583. Dr. Wise refers to this catastrophe in his article, already referred to. In one of the ballads on Ishā Khan, we find a curious story that one of the Dewans, after Ishā Khan's death, had set fire to the palace of Jangal Bāri and destroyed his whole family, because the Delhi troops had peeped into his Zenana. The sense of honour of the Dewan must have been so delicate as to verge on madness. But the whole thing seems to me to be a mere piece of fancy and nothing more than that. When we read a ballad, composed by an illiterate peasant, his accounts are generally found correct, at least his mistakes are *bona-fide*. But when a half-lettered villager garbles out a tale with the conscious effort of making a display, we cannot conceive to what extent he may show the monstrous range of his fancy by distorting facts. The author of the ballad in question seems to us to belong to that school. He tells us that as soon as Dewan Abdul heard that the Delhi troops, his own allies, had constructed a high ladder with bamboo-poles out of curiosity and peeped into his Zenana, having a full view of the ladies, he was covered with a sense of disgrace and ordered that all the gates of the inner apartment should be shut. He then proceeded to set fire to the palace, which was burnt down to ashes with its inmates, and only a poor baby of six months, Machoom Khan survived, having been thrown down by a maid-servant from over the roof into the basket of a fisher-woman, who saved the poor thing from

death. All other members of the Dewan family and their attendants died in the conflagration as the doors were shut from outside; and this is the way in which the Dewan Saheb revenged himself upon the Delhi troops !

The whole seems to be a myth, pure and simple. But I refer to the story for one reason. May it not be taken as indicating some historical event, relating to an expedition of the Imperialists into Jangal Bāri and the subsequent destruction of the palace by them ? The incident is said to have occurred shortly after Adam and Birām had returned to the palace, having married the two daughters of Kedar Ray. If there is any grain of truth in this account, it certainly hints at a tragedy, in which the princes met with a melancholy end. There seems to have been some popular tradition of the Jangal Bāri palace being destroyed by the Moghul army and of the consequent destruction of many members of the Dewan family. Such a tragic event could not but have left an impression on the popular mind. But the author of the ballad would not like to describe an event, showing the defeat of the invincible Dewans, whose prowess he had extolled beyond all measure, —even to the extent of declaring that Ishā Khan had usurped the throne of Delhi and thereby struck terror into the heart of Humayun. Thus he gave out a version, monstrously distorted, in which he attempted to prove how delicate was the sense of family honour with the Dewans !

The ballad-maker also states that the army of the Moghuls was one thousand in number and that they had lived for six months at the cost of the Dewan Sahib. All this hints at some altercation in which the Moghul army suddenly besieged the palace of Jangal Bāri and

setting fire to it, destroyed it with many of the members of the Dewan family. .t is also mentioned in the ballad that for fourteen years the Jangal Bāri palace was in a deserted condition and when Machoom Khan, the surviving scion of the family in that locality, grew to be a lad of fourteen, he was invited by the people to take the reins of administration in his hands and that he had the old mansion, thoroughly repaired, before he sat on the '*gadi*' of his ancestors.

The destruction of the residence of Ishā Khan at Baktiarpur in 1583 by Shah Baz Khan has already been mentioned by me. Through the vista of these tragical incidents in the family of the Dewans, we have glimpses of events, which may indicate some catastrophic end of the sons of Subhadrā. At the same time it must be admitted that the genealogical accounts of the Dewan family, that have been hitherto available to us, are neither exhaustive nor accurate. In Dr. Wise's table we find that the line of Haibatnagar is descended from a brother of Ishā Khan, whereas the genealogy, given by Mr. Stapleton and in the 'Itihasā' it is traced directly from Ishā Khan. Not only are discrepancies of this sort very common, but throughout Mymensingh, there are innumerable families, who claim their descent from Ishā Khan. Some of these are undoubtedly "Nazar Marichar Chhele" or descended from the beautiful Hindu maidens, brought into the harem of the Dewans in lieu of "Nazar Marichā" or marriage-tax. I have written about them in full in my Introduction to the first part of the ballads. These children of "Nazar Marichā" not only inherited their paternal property but were called Dewans by courtesy. None of these lines would now admit that they are descended from Hindu women in that way, for reasons I have

stated in connection with Subhadrā. It is impossible to collect a genealogical account of the different branches of the Dewan family, some of whom have sunk into abject poverty and low status and lost all touch with the main stock. In the face of these difficulties, it is not possible to find out any clue as to the immediate descendants of Âdam and Birām, if they lived long enough to have issue. But as I have already stated, it seems certain that they were sons of Ishā Khan by Subhadrā and that their uncle Kedar Ray had tried his best to revenge himself upon the innocent lads for the fault, if any, of their mother, who, instead of committing suicide by 'Jahar Brata' or courting death in some other way, had clung to Ishā Khan as a devoted wife and thus brought a great disgrace on the Rāj family of Sripur.[1]

[1] Babu Swarup Chandra Ray in his 'Suvarna Grāmer Itihāsa,' published in 1891, gives some interesting facts about Sonāmani. He says that Sonāmani was abducted by Ishā Khan with the help of a treacherous officer of Chand Ray, who had been bribed by the Dewan. It is said that a good many bloody wars were fought between Chand Ray and Ishā Khan over the great insult, done to the noble Hindu family. Chand Roy seriously damaged the fort of Ishā Khan, built by him at Kalaigachha and devastated the town of Khijirpur, which had once been the capital of the Moslem Chief. It has been further stated that after Ishā Khan's death, Chand Ray plundered the town of Jangal Bāri and tried various other ways to take revenge on his family.

It is also related that Sonāmani met a tragic end. She fought hard against the Burmese marauders, who had laid seize to the fort of Hazigunj, in which she had taken refuge. But being unable to hold her own, she courted death by throwing herself into fire, for fear of being captured by the enemy. We find, also, a statement to the effect that the Tipperah Raja joined with the Burme se and Kedar Ray of Vikrampur in attacking Jangal Bāri and plundering it after the death of Ishā Khan. We have already referred to the fact, on the authority of the Rajmala, that Ishā Khan was once a great ally of Raja Amar Mānikya. That latterly there was an estrangement of feeling between the Moslem Chief and the Tipperah Raja may be inferred from the fact that no notice was taken, even by the ballad-makers of Mymensingh, of the hard fight which Ishā Khan had once fought in the interest of the Tipperah State. They wanted to obliterate all memory of Ishā Khan's association with Tipperah. According to the "Suvarna Grāmer Itīhāsa," Ādam and Birām had no issue. Like one or two other historical accounts, this Itīhāsa states that Sonāmani was *a daughter and not a sister* of Chand Ray.

In the account given by the Dewans, we find Mānsing's wife, appealing with tears to Ishā Khan to agree to accompany her husband to Delhi. The plea was that if he would not comply, the Emperor was sure to behead her husband. And Dewan Ishā Khan, taking pity on her, gallantly agreed to be taken as a captive to Delhi and allowed himself to be thrown into prison there with the noble purpose of saving Mansing's life from the wrath of the autocratic Emperor. This story evidently exaggerates the valour and other noble qualities of Ishā Khan at the cost of Mānsing, who is represented here as a general of no high merit, if not altogether a coward. Dr. Wise has believed in this story furnished by the Dewan family. But the popular version, written by a Mahomedan ballad-maker, gives a more reliable account. It glorifies Ishā Khan without lowering Mānsing. The valour of the former is praised ; he is represented as holding his own in the fort of Egar Sindura like a brave hero that he was. It, besides, gives details of the stratagem, employed by Mānsing to make him a captive. The whole thing appears quite natural. It does not diminish the glory either of Ishā Khan or of Mānsing and describes the situation very well in which both these warriors found ample opportunities to discover, and appreciate their respective merits in the battle-field, eventually leading to the release of Ishā Khan from the prison of Delhi and to the bestowal of great favours on him by the Emperor through the intercession of Mānsing.

Some historians have recorded that Kedar Ray died of the effect of an wound, received in battle with Mānsing. The ballad, however, gives a totally different account. Mānsing came to Bengal to subdue some of of the refractory chiefs of Bengal and he no doubt

fought with Kedar Ray. It is not unlikely that the latter was wounded in some affray with the great general of Akbar. If it was true that Karimulla actually killed Kedar Ray, as stated in the ballad, it would still be quite possible for Mānsing to have appropriated the credit to himself in his report to the Delhi Emperor. The reputation of Karimulla, a village hero, could not have possibly gone beyond Bengal. In the ballad of Manoowar Khan, we find that Sripur was destroyed by the army of Jangal Bāri with the help received from Delhi. So the heroic exploits and successes, achieved by Karimulla, might have been ignored by the great generals of Delhi, in their accounts, sent to Delhi, in order to appropriate the entire credit and full share of glory to themselves.

Ishā Khan, it is indicated in the Muhammadan chronicles, reigned "from Ghoraghat to sea." It is not true that the other eleven sub-lords of Bengal admitted him as their feudal lord. It may be said with some certainty that he was the most powerful of them. Kedar Ray reigned at Sripur, which once stood on the banks of the Padmā. On the bank of that river was Khijirpur, once the principal seat of Ishā Khan. The grandeur of the city of Sripur is on record and Kedar Ray seems to have wielded a great power over the tract of land from Sripur to Dacca. Karimulla, the famous general of the Dewan family, found himself safe from his jurisdiction, while reaching the latter city, where a strong Mahomedan power was stationed, as we come to learn from the ballads. Kedar Ray and Chand Ray reigned over the large and important Perganna of Vikrampur, "and between Ishā Khan of Khijirpur, whose strength was on the opposite bank of the Ganges (Padmā) and the two brothers, there was constant warfare." The historic temple at Rājbāri

which was reckoned as one of the typical monuments of Bengali sculpture and which Dr. Wise has described in detail, has recently been washed away by the treacherous river, on the bank of which it stood. The temple was associated with Kedar Ray. But the temple evidently bore signs of Pre-Muhammadan art and showed many features of Buddhist sculpture. Dr. Wise, while assigning its foundation to Kedar Ray, remarks, "The walls are eleven feet thick, larger than those found in Mahomedan buildings of the same age, being eight inches square and one and a half thick." The massive walls are of the pre-Mahomedan period and the vast reservoir in front of the monument, called "Keshaber Mār dighi" is probably indicative of some forgotten lady, at whose order the *Math* was founded. We cannot endorse Dr. Wise's statement on the authority of an absurd rustic story that the *Dighi* was constructed by one of the servants of Kedar Ray. The *Math* and the tank are always constructed together by the same person. My belief is that the *Math* was built in the Buddhist times and that Kedar Ray and Chand Ray had it thoroughly repaired and associated it latterly with their own names. Its archæological features have led us to derive this conclusion. With this historic edifice, Eastern Bengal has probably lost one of her noblest of monuments of the Buddhist age.

After the settlement of Bengal in Akbar's reign, Ishā Khan is said to have possessed 22 pergannas in Eastern Bengal, the names of which are mentioned in the body of the texts. The original residence of the family, as has already been stated, was at Baiswari in Oudh. Mr. Stapleton says "Bais and yāra" written without spaces on either side of the "ও" is simply Baiswara. The name Baiswara has apparently reference to 22 pergannas, held by these Rajputs, and the fact that Ishā Khan was also

granted the same number of Pergannas in Eastern Bengal may be regarded as some actual proof of his descent from the Rajputs of Baiswara."

The ballads give accurate details of customs and manners prevalent in Eastern Bengal in the 16th century. They refer to the artistic designs, with which bungalows were constructed in the district of Mymensingh in those days. The feathers of the crane, of the king-fishers and of the pea-cocks were used in plenty for the purpose of decorating the roofs. It was a fashion to erect a number of crystal pillars in the mansions of the nobles and chiefs. The relics of such pillars are to be found even to this day in the débris of the palatial buildings of Mujlis Jelal. We also come to learn from these ballads that the big boats, which still go by the name of "koshã" in Eastern Bengal is suggestive of the fact that in olden times, a whole fleet would be so large as to cover two miles—a *krosha*. Of course Ishā Khan's 'koshā,' though undoubtedly a very big one, was far from being the monster-ship of the ancient Hindus and only proved the tradition of the old-world trading vessels. In ancient times it was the fashion to construct huge things. The Babylonians and Egyptians were famous for building gigantic monuments. This fashion was preserved till much later times in India. Huen-tshang saw, in Northern India, many huge figures of the Buddha, one of which stood as high as the Ochterloney monument, and that is a matter of the seventh century A. D.

We come to know from the ballads that the Muhammadan ladies of high rank used to wear Persian '*saris*' in those days and young Moslem noblemen favoured coats, made in Egypt. They wore caps made in Arabia, and used gorgeous shoes and slippers, inlaid with jewels, made by Persian artists.

Dr. Wise refers to the three Sanads, preserved by the Jangal Bāri family.

The first is from Shah Suja and is dated the 21st Julas of Shah Jehan A. H. 1057 (1647 A. D.) It directs Ahmad and Iwaz Muhammad, members of the family, to pay the revenues of the estates, jointly held by them to I't Quid Khan.

The second is dated A. H. 1059 (1649 A. D.) and is sent by Shah Suzā to the Munsabdars and other officials to make over some dockyards, which had previously been built by the government.

The third is dated 1700 A. D. and is an order from Azim ush Khan requiring Haibat Mahomed to keep in readiness 37 koshā-boats with 32 boatmen in each and to pay Rs. 10,267-7, the revenue of the Pergannas Budak'hāl, etc.

The ballad of Manowar Khan, which, for some reasons, we cannot publish in this volume, scarcely possesses any rural simplicity or directness, which is the most important characteristic of this class of songs. In it we come across the pedantry of a half-lettered village-poet, reminding us often of the age of Bhārat Chandra, when amorous subjects carried to abnormal excesses, received favour. But in Bhārat Chandra, his inimitably finished style, the classical dignity of words and their wealth of music invest even the most erotic matters with a literary fineness which, to some extent, hides the nudity of a disgusting scene. Many of his imitators, however, without possessing the grace and scholarship of the great master, imbibed his faults to a point outrageous to decency. Though this ballad may be charged with some of these blemishes, it no doubt gives us some real accounts of Manowar Khan and his dealings with Shah Sujā, from which the historian will be able to trace the later

career of that unfortunate prince, now covered with a mist, which hardly leaves a vista to give some glimpses into the real facts of that period of his life. This account, coupled with that to be found in one of the works of the celebrated Mahomedan poet Alwal are perhaps the only source from which an account of the later events of Shāh Suza's life may be gleaned.[1]

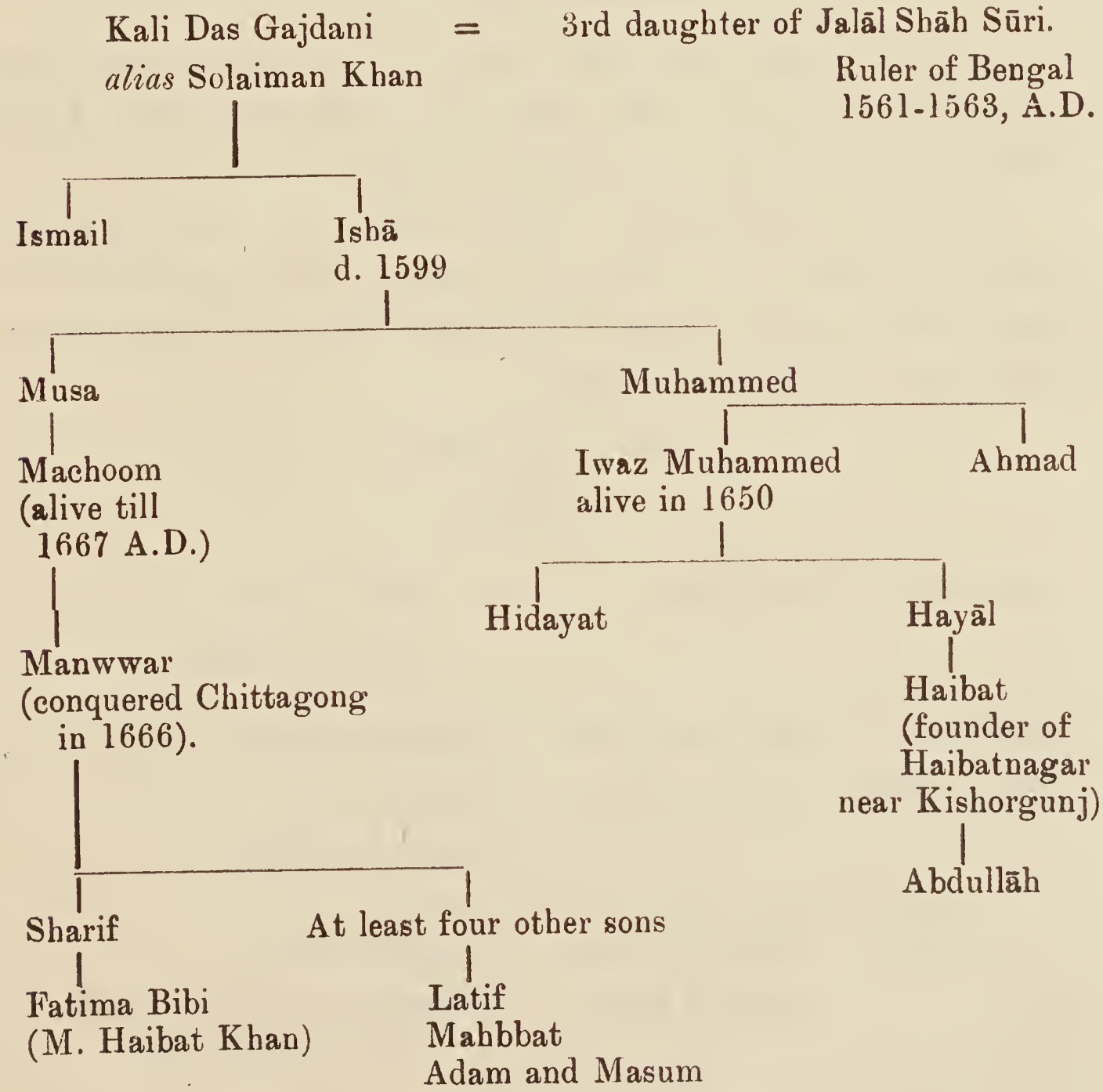
In these historical ballads, we can hardly expect to meet with much poetry. But still the ballad of Ferōz Khan gives a picture of a real epic grandeur towards the end in the death of Sakhina,—a picture which, more than brass or marble, is a lasting memorial to that great heroine, presenting her unique and sublime martyrdom for love in the rude but simple language of the rustic poet.

We have noticed the episode fully in our Introduction to the first volume. Though lacking in poetry, these ballads do not lack in interest. In most of these, the reader follows the incidents described, with ardent curiosity and these descriptions have none of that haziness, which characterise the flamboyant and frothy style of some of our modern writers, but are vivid and always relevant to the point. Conciseness is generally the special quality of the ballads and their authors seldom use two words, when they can convey their idea by one.

[1] We have just received information from Babu Ashutosh Chowdhury, one of our ballad-collectors, that he has heard some ballads describing the love of a daughter of Sāh Suza with a Burmese prince. The ballad-maker humourously asks the Moslem princess as to how she would wear *lungi* in the place of her gown and adapt herself to other curious ways of Burmese life. The ballad was sung to Ashu Babu by some Bediyas of Chittagong.

A Comparative Review of the Genealogical Records of the Dewan Family.

We subjoin here three genealogical tables which we have got of Ishā Khan's family. Of these the one given by Mr. Stapleton in his article published in the Journal of Asiatic Society of Bengal for 1909 is based on the Masnadali Itihas written by Munshi Raj Chandra Ghosh and Pandit Kali Kumar Chakraborty. We give Mr. Stapleton's table below.[1]



1 The table is given with good many omissions, specially in respect of the matrimonial alliances contracted by the family.

(2) Table given by Munshi Abdul Karim of the village Galāchipa in the Subdivision of Kishorgunj (Mymensingh) in his Ballad of Manwwar Khan.

Kali Das Gazdani, m. a daughter of Babar
alias Solaiman
Khan
|
Dewan Isā Khan
|
Abdul Khan
|
Machoom Khan
|
Manwwar Khan

In the ballad of Ishā Khan, Abdul Karim says that Machoom Khan had five sons, *viz.*, Manwwarali, Latif Amirali, Lātif Khan and Haibat Khan.

(3) The genealogical table given in 'the Subarna Gramer Itihas' by Swarup Chandra Roy, published by Lalit Mohan Das from the Sakha Press, 33, Musalman Para Lane, Calcutta, in 1891.

Kali Das Gazdani
|
Ishā Khan

Adam Khan, Biram Khan — Abdul Khan
Machoom Khan

Latif Khan — Khodadad Ali
Mahammed Khan — Ali Noaz Khan
Manwwar Khan — Bulban Khan — Alimurdan Khan
Sarif Khan

Lal Khan
Kamarali Khan — Omedali Khan — Hasan Ali — Umed Ali
Enait Ali
Samshor Khan — Bahadur Ali, Kumar Ali and Jamsher Khan
Ehadali



Mosque and ruins of house of Ishā Khan's immediate descendants. P. 335

The two tables, *viz.*, the one given by Itihāsa and the other, for the most part, copied from it by Mr. Stapleton are practically the same, though the latter has the value of important footnotes by that scholar. But from a comparison of the other three tables and references to the genealogy of the family in the article of Dr. Wise, it appears that none of these has any substantial claim to reliability. The table given by Babu Swarup Chandra Ray was no doubt, collected from a branch of the Dewan family, settled in some locality near Suvarnagrām and reveals names, which are mostly not to be found in the other tables. The fact is that the descendants of the Dewans, legitimate and illegitimate, all called Dewans by true lineage or by courtesy, are so numerous and their status so varied that each of these families has a different record of its own, sometimes manipulated by the members in such a way as to enable them to establish their claims on direct descent from the main stock by lawful marriage. It is difficult to find out a real and accurate record from the forest of genealogies, supplied by ignorant and illiterate people.

Dewan Isha Khan Mashnad Ali.

Chorus :—

"Let the drum beat in honour of Ishā Khan."

(1)

In the Western country there was a Raja named Dhanapat Singh. He was a great chief and his riches were immense. His slaves and maid-servants were innumerable. He was on terms of great intimacy with the Emperor of Delhi, who protected him at the hour of danger—as does the shadow of a tree the weary passenger scorched by the rays of the sun.

In the family of Raja Dhanapat Singh was born, in course of years, Raja Bhagirath, the worthy scion of an illustrious aristocratic family, who, for the well-being of his subjects, was ready to sacrifice every interest,—nay his life. Raja Bhagirath in course of his travels, visiting the Indian shrines, came last to the province of Bengal. After he had seen different parts of the country, he visited Gour—its capital, where Sultan Ghyas Uddin was reigning at that time. The Sultan received the Raja very warmly in his court and treated him with every mark of respect. It is only the noble heart that can appreciate nobility in others. Says the poet—"To the dog clarified butter has no taste or value."

The Sultan began to admire the noble qualities of Raja Bhagirath and with earnest entreaties persuaded him to accept the post of his Prime Minister and to stay at his capital. So Raja Bhagirath settled at Gour and

by his piety and administrative talents soon made himself esteemed of all. The subjects of the Empire he treated as his children. No one ever saw him indulge in pride, though he held such an exalted position. His fame soon spread far and wide in the country.

From him was descended Kālidas, who, in his turn, held the rank of the Prime Minister of the Sultan of Gour. Jāinuddin was at that time on the throne of of Bengal.

Now, Kālidas, the Prime Minister, was a youth of exceedingly handsome appearance,—in fact, among the youthful members of aristocratic rank none was equal to him in personal attractions. He shone, as it were, with the brilliance of the sun. If the minister stood in a dark chamber, it appeared that its darkness was dispelled in an instant. Even Madan, the God of love—husband of Rati, was no match for him in personal grace and beauty.

He was, besides, known for his extensive charity. The poor people and the Fakirs daily received gifts at his hands. His court was a resort of scholars and ascetics. With their advice the minister performed the duties of his responsible office. At his order the figure of an elephant used to be cast in gold every morning, and this he gave as a gift to the Brahmins daily. For this, Kalidas, the minister, was popularly known by the title of 'Gajdāni' or 'the giver of elephants.' In his eyes there was no distinction between the Hindus and Muhammadans. There was no envy or spite in his soul. Every year he performed with great *eclat* the ceremonies of Dol—the swinging ceremony of Krishna—and the Durgotsava (the well-known Pujas held in October). Besides these, he performed all other ceremonies mentioned in the Hindu almanac, omitting none. He kept in his palatial

house a collection of all kinds of rare things, some as curiosities and others for luxury or use. If any of his friends wanted anything from him he offered it with sincere love to oblige him. If a foreigner became a guest at his house, he was hospitality itself, while entertaining him. And until the guest was served he never tasted a morsel himself. In a word, there was scarcely another man in the country as conscientious, honest and good as Kālidas Gajdāni.

Bahadur Shaha had died without leaving any issue after having spent large sums on religious purposes and in charity. And on his death, Jainuddin (Jalaluddin) was installed on the throne of Gour, and young Kālidas as Prime Minister was at the head of the administration of Bengal. (Ll. 1-56.)

(2)

Jālāluddin had a daughter named Maminā Khātun, beautiful as the moon. Many young princes came to Gour seeking her hands but she did not choose any of them. So they went away disappointed. No young man did she find as accomplished as could win her heart. So the world lost all its charm for her. Now brethren, allow me a little time to describe her beauty. Like a living flame in a lonely place, her charms unfolded themselves brightening the Sultan's harem. Her long hair flowed down her waist in profuse curls. Her face was like the moon and her eyes were lovely as those of a gazelle. The fairies, when they beheld her, felt ashamed of themselves and readily admitted their inferiority. Youth had just dawned on her. With her attending maids did she spend her time gaily in sweet talks. When she walked, it seemed that a flood of beauty flowed on the earth. She appeared too delicate to bear the burden of her

growing charms. Alas, who is that fortunate soul for whom God had created this maiden, exhausting all His artistic skill!

One day she happened to go to the bathing *ghat* of the river, surrounded by her maidens. And there on the way she saw Kālidas the minister. As soon as she saw him the surprising beauty of his person maddened her soul. She forgot herself and stood transfixed to the spot, glancing at his noble form.

From that day she did not relish her daily meals, and the whole night she lay on her bed without sleeping for a moment. At last she took a desperate step. She wrote a letter to Kālidas Gajdāni and handing it over to one of her maids said, "Go with this to Kālidas Gajdāni." The letter ran thus, "I have been yearning for you. From the day I saw you first, I have been feeling as if I should leave my house, kinsmen and all and join you. I should like to be your slave though I am a princess. I value you, dear lord, as does the blind man his eyes that he has regained."

The maid-servant started with the letter and reached the place of the minister. She unloosed it from the edge of her *sadi* wherein she had tied it, and handed it over to him.

The minister read the letter attentively; a smile was observed on his lips as he finished reading; and then he returned to his private chamber and cautiously wrote a reply to this effect:—

"Esteemed princess, listen to my advice and do not take me amiss. I am indeed very sorry for you. You are a Muhammadan and I am a Hindu. How can there be a marriage between us unless we profess the same religion? By my life, I cannot give up my faith and turn a Muhammadan; your beauty I do greatly admire,

but this valuable thing I should not purchase at the price of my religion. Rather should I beg alms from door to door and turn a Fakir, than forego my religion by marrying a Muhammadan. Were I born a Muhammadan, there could be nothing to obstruct our union. If I forego my religion, my *shastras* say that I shall have to pay the penalty of great sufferings in seven future lives. So, do please accept my advice, esteemed princess, change the course of your mind and do not entertain the sort of feeling that you are now indulging in."

With this letter the maid-servant returned to the princess. (Ll. 1-58.)

(3)

When she read the contents of the letter, the face of Maminā Khātun reddened in humiliated pride and deep shame. She spent her nights and days absolutely without a wink of sleep in her eyes, she did not eat her daily meal, nor drink water, when thirsty. She took the silent vow of starving herself to death to hide her disappointment and shame.

But at a second thought she devised a plan, and resolved to destory the caste of Kālidas by a stratagem. She privately called the cook of the minister to the palace and contrived the following plan; she would have meals prepared at the palace and trust it to the cook. The minister would confidently partake of it without suspecting any foul play. If the cook could successfully carry out this plan, he would be rewarded with the grant of one *pura* of land; besides a beautiful bride would be secured for him and provision would be made for the maintenance of the couple, so that he would no longer have to earn his living by serving

others. The cook was gratified at this prospect and assented to the princess's wishes.

A rich *Kabab* was prepared with the meat of goat and beef. *Kurmā* and *Koptā* and various other dainties were also prepared and sent from the palace to the minister's cook who served him the meal at dinner-time. The cook told his minister that some special preparations had been made by him that day with great care. Kalidas was pleased with what he ate and had a pleasant sleep in the night. In the morning the cook appeared before his master and said, "I took recourse to a stratagem and made you eat beef last night. You saw the beef with your own eyes and ate the forbidden meat. I was employed to adopt this device in order to destroy your caste and I have succeeded in doing so."

Not a moment did he tarry after this short speech but instantly bolted away from the place. (Ll. 1-34.)

(4)

The minister began to lament and say, "Who is the person at whose instigation the fellow dared to ruin me thus?" He struck his head with his hands and said again and again, "Who is such an enemy of mine that has thus ruined my position in society?" He bitterly lamented his fate and turned half-mad with grief. Finally he determined to put an end to his life and said, "What is the use of this cursed life? When my caste is gone, I will tie a halter round my neck and commit suicide".

When the minister in deep anguish abandoned his home and wandered about in the streets like a mad man, the Emperor Jalaluddin called him to the palace privately and gave him some good advice. He said, "The decree of God is inviolable. Is it not your good

luck that you have turned a Muhammadan ? If you behave like a mad man what good will you reap from such a course ? Give up despair and try to compose yourself. I may now call you a Muhammadan as you have lost your religion, why not marry my daughter ? She is a beautiful girl. I propose that you do marry her. You know that I have no son. So after my death you will inherit all that I have. All my riches and property will be yours. So you see that you lose nothing but gain much by becoming a Muhammadan."

When the minister heard these words of the Sultan, he thus thought within himself, " Indeed, why should I act like a mad fellow ? Now I have practically become a Muhammadan being an outcast and it is not in my power to become a Hindu again. What is the reason that I should give up all the good prospects of my life ? I shall marry the princess and accept the proposal of the Sultan. And then in due course when I shall be the Sultan of this province, there will be nothing to regret in future."

Now hear me, my learned audience, what happened next. The name of Kālidas was changed into Sulaman Khan. He performed the 'Jumma' ceremony at the sight of the young moon. The marriage of Sulaman with Maminā was duly performed. It was stipulated in writing that all the property of the Sultan would, on his death, pass on to Sulaman. Sulaman was pleased with this marriage and the prospects that it gave him. He lived happily with Maminā Khātun and in course of time had two sons by her. He gave them the names of Dāud Khan and Isā Khan respectively.

For fifteen years Sulaman reigned in Gour and then departed from this world. Dāud Khan succeeded him on the throne of Gour and in great pride stopped paying

revenue to the Emperor of Delhi. The latter sent one of his officers to Dāud with a mandate for immediate payment of his arrears.

Dāud heaped insults on him and then turned him out of the court. The officer returned to his master in Delhi and conveyed to him the news of the treatment he had received from the Sultan of Bengal. He added in conclusion, "Oh my Master, my life was spared, but I was so severely beaten that my limbs seem to have been paralysed. Such an enemy should at once be killed either in an open battle or by some stratagem." The Emperor was greatly enraged, and sent an army to Gour. A severe fight took place between the army of the Emperor and that of Dāud Khan with the result that the latter was killed. (Ll. 1-56.)

(5)

Isā Khan succeeded him on the throne of Gour. He ruled his subjects with affection and was ever ready to undergo great personal sacrifice for them. After three years Isā Khan too stopped paying revenue to the Delhi Emperor. The Emperor on hearing this, sent five *kahans* of soldiers to Gour with the order "Get Isā Khan up here, bound in chains, forcibly or by some stratagem." Shahabaj Khan, the Foujdar, well-known for his martial abilities far and near, was placed at the head of the army to conduct the expedition. There was none in the country to match him in the battle-field. He crushed all the enemies of the empire wherever they mustered strong. When such a great champion appeared in the field, Isā Khan being well-equipped, stood facing him with firm resolve. Isā Khan, the hero of a hundred fight, killed countless enemies and Shahabaj fought with equal valour. In fact, they looked like Hassen and Hossen. The

army of Ishā Khan was extirpated and he alone was left in the field. At this crisis he saw no other course left to him than to retreat from the place. He crossed canals and rivers and fled through forests and dales and thus saved himself from the enemy. He reached Chittagong safe. There was none amongst the enemy who had the courage or tact to overtake him. From Chittagong, he came to the city of Dacca and spent his nights in the forests. In course of his flight from Chittagong he had brought some cats with him. He had nothing with him to feed these poor creatures. In a jungly land he let these cats loose. When they pursued some rats, curiously the latter seized the cats and killed them. Ishā Khan wondered at this strange sight and declared that he had never seen rats killing cats anywhere. "Here shall I settle with bag and baggage. Here I shall be able to make the impossible happen. I must build my residential house here in this jungle."

In that forest there dwelt two chiefs named Ram and Lakshmana. They were brothers and belonged to the *Koch* tribe. In the depth of night, hiding himself in darkness, Ishā Khan attacked their palace with the object of killing the brothers. They had, however, been apprised of their danger beforehand and fled from the place in precipitous haste and were never heard of in that part of the country again.

Ishā Khan had the jungle cleared and founded a city which he called Jangal Bāri. He prepared plans of a palace and other buildings with the help of experts and constructed the city in the most approved methods of that age.

He had beautiful houses raised in the inner compartment. The roofs were covered with the picturesque feathers of king-fishers. Each room was furnished with

glass-doors. The pillars were made of crystal which sparkled in the rays of the sun. The outer houses had their roofs covered with the milk-white feathers of cranes. The palace was surrounded by a ditch. The audience—Hall was a *bunglow* with roofs decorated with peacock-feathers. Ishā Khan used to hold his *durbar* in that hall. Many garden-houses were built with beautiful tanks dug inside them, some of square and others of a circular shape. Formerly it was a jungle infested with tigers and bears, now it was made a flourishing city retaining its old name Jangal Bāri, or the Wood-land Palace. Brilliant and smiling was the city like the moon, having no place to match it in the whole world.

Enthroned there in his new city, Ishā Khan now set his whole heart to extend the jurisdiction of his kingdom. He increased his army, which now consisted of innumerable soldiers. Many forts were constructed in various centres. The report of all this procedure reached, in course of time, the ears of the Emperor of Delhi who sent one of his officers in order to summon Ishā Khan to Delhi. On receiving the summons the Chief of Jangal Bāri had the officer arrested and placed a heavy stone on his breast. He kept him confined in this condition, in his prison. One month—two months, the whole year passed but the officer never returned to Delhi. The Emperor consulted the almanac and fixed an auspicious day when he sent an army placing Raja Mansingh at the head. There was none who could cope with the Raja. The enemies of the Emperor he used to destroy with the ease with which one cuts the *kusha* plant (a species of esculent roots).

The first battle was fought at a place called *Bukāi*. Ishā Khan was made to retire from Bukai to Sherpur. He was pursued and pushed his way from Sherpur and

took refuge in the fort of Dewan-bāg. Thence he went to Murapara. Thus the chief of Jangal Bāri moved from fort to fort; and Mansingh pursued him all the while driving him from all his strong positions. But still the Raja could not overtake him till he was tired by his pursuit. He took recourse to a stratagem to catch hold of the wild hero. The last place where Ishā Khan had taken refuge was the fort of Egaro Sindur. From here he heard a report that Mansingh, weary of pursuing him, had resolved to return to Delhi. Right glad at this news, Ishā Khan, with the generals of his army, passed the night in merriment and glee. Now, Mansingh had constructed strong iron cages which he placed at the several gate-ways of the fort of Egaro Sindur. So any one who attempted to come out would be caught in the trap. The Raja now set fire to the fort. The inmates could no longer stay but tried to escape and in their attempts, found themselves entangled within the cages placed at the gate-ways. Ishā Khan shared the fate of his followers and was thus caught by the Raja. The cage in which Ishā Khan had been put was now carried to Delhi on the back of an elephant.

One day—two days—a week passed; no one took any notice of the prisoner. His position was exactly like that of a lion fallen into a snare. No proper food was given to the chief who suffered intensely from hunger and thirst. He thus reflected within himself, "If I could but once make my escape from here, I would see how the Emperor reigns supreme in future."

One day the Emperor Akbar with his viziers and other courtiers sat in his *durbar* and called Mansingh to his presence. He asked the Raja to give him a report of war. Mansingh was pleased at this order and said, "Many a battle have I fought, Oh monarch, many a great

wrestler and sturdy soldier have I seen, but I never saw a valorous champion in the field like Ishā Khan. I think there does not exist a second hero in your realms, possessed of such superior skill and valour as this chief. Your Majesty has cruelly deprived him of his usual meals and ordinary comforts of life. He has been suffering greatly. Such a handsome man as he is, he now looks emaciated and pale. If your Majesty would place him under an obligation by a show of courtesy that a hero of his merit deserves, he may render valuable service to the state in future. If your Majesty can subdue the enemy by good treatment, he will be eventually won over to your side. It is well-known that this Ishā Khan is not an ordinary man; if he can make his escape, he may be a source of trouble to the Empire in future. It will be well if your Majesty talks with him face to face. I am sure, it will lead to a mutual understanding, removing all feelings of hostility.

The Emperor, on hearing the words of the Raja, himself paid a visit to the prison and said to the prisoner, "I am very sorry that your dress is so unseemly and bad. I repent my cruelty towards you. I am going to release you from the prison"—saying so Akbar with his own hands, released the chief.

The chief, regaining his freedom, fell at the feet of the Emperor and bending low on the ground craved his Majesty's forgiveness. The Emperor was right glad at the conduct of the chief and lifting him up from the ground, embraced him. The Emperor then made Ishā Khan sit by his side at the *Durbar* and showed him great marks of honour before his courtiers. He, moreover, conferred on him the title of "Mashnadali" with a *sanad*—granting him the ownership of 22 perganas on an annual revenue of Rs. 10,000. The names of the perganas are

as follow—'Sherpur,' 'Joyan Shai,' 'Alapsingh,' 'Joarsai,' 'Nashir-u-Jiral,' 'Mymensingh,' 'Khaliajuri,' 'Gangamandal,' 'Paitkara,' 'Baradakhat,' 'Svarnagram,' 'Baradakhatmanra,' 'Husen sahi,' 'Bhawal,' 'Maheswardi,' 'Katrar,' 'Kurikhai,' 'Sinda,' 'Hajradi,' 'Darjibazu,' 'Goair,' 'Husenpur.'

Ishā Khan started for Jangal Bāri with the Emperor's *sanad*. He had constructed a ship at Delhi, which was a curiosity, drawing admiration from people far and near. It was 150,000 yards in length and 2,000 yards in breadth and 100 yards high. The ship moved covering an area of 2 miles (a krosh), hence it was called 'Koshā.' The ship was manned by 2,000 oarsmen. The captain of the ship was a man named Shadhan, an inhabitant of a village on the banks of the Padmā. When the oars were plied by thousands of hands, the ship flew swiftly like the wind. It seemed, as if it could, if it wished, run on dry lands. Ishā Khan came on board this ship which was decorated with flags and *ensigns* and started homewards. The Emperor embraced him before he parted and sent with him twelve officers of his court to escort him. With the speed of the wind, pushed by sixteen thousand oars the ship moved on like a bird in the air.* In a moment she passed many a lake, many a river and many a canal and last of all reached the great river Padmā. Downstream the ship marched, spreading her sails and in her front, lay the city of Sripur, where Kedar Roy reigned. He had hundreds of officers, courtiers and ministers and the people of that country held him in great esteem. His wealth was unbounded and his palace abounded with

* This ship is a evidently myth, but there is this substratum of truth in the that story, Isha Khan had really constructed a gigantic ship which took the shape of this wild and monstrously exaggerated picture in rustic fancy.

innumerable servants and dependents. The city smiled with many a temple and building. A staircase made of white stone descended from the city to the river, and here and there peeped from the forest-groves brick houses of varied colour. There were many three-storeyed and four-storeyed houses in that city and as the '*kosha*' of Ishā Khan passed by the river, favoured by the currents, people gathered on her banks to see it, (Ll. 1-176).

(6)

From the ship the Moslem-chief observed a fair maiden sporting with her gay companions on the roof of a three-storied building. It appeared that the whole mansion was lit up by her beauty. Ishā Khan had never seen a maiden as beautiful as she. The chief fixed his gaze at her, awaiting the prospect of exchanging a glance. She was playing "Palā buji" with her maids. Suddenly her eyes fell on the waters of the Padmā where she beheld the handsome chief gazing at her. Eyes met eyes at an auspicious moment. Love thus sprang in both the hearts. Four eyes met and the sequel was fraught with important historical developments. Oh my audience, listen to what happened later on, as the result of this love.

The maiden and her companions wondered at the size and grandeur of the ship, which seemed to have covered the whole river as far as they could see. They all beheld the ship with curious eyes but she cared not to see what they so eagerly saw, keeping her gaze fixed on the handsome person of the master of the ship. As she beheld the youth, her eyes were tinged with passion ; she lost not a moment, but entered her bed-room and hastily wrote a letter which she put inside a cork. Then she went to the bathing ghat. The ship was moored to the bank and there she sported with her maids who were never weary of admiring



"She came, as expected, for bathing, a short while after." P. 351.

the ship. But her thirsty eyes sought the figure of the noble chief. Just at that moment Ishā Khan stood on board the ship in the mid-stream and four eyes again met. Casting her glance at him, she floated the cork in the current. The chief saw that something was thrown into the river, meant for him. The cork, meanwhile, came floating near the boat and he instantly took it up in his hand. He now drew the letter out and began to read it. When the maiden saw this, she returned homeward with her companions.

The contents of the letter were as follows :—

"Oh stranger, my heart has become mad for you. You saw me when I was bathing,—my mind yearns for you,—I care not for my religion or for my society. In you I will find all that is dear to me. If you feel any compassion for me, hasten to meet me. In the month of Chaitra (April), on the eighth day of the waxing moon, I will come to the landing ghat of the Padma for bathing again. Come with a strong army on that day with your ship and carry me by force. Come with a large number of oarsmen, so that the ship may go with the utmost speed. Bear this in mind that if my brother can overtake the ship, destruction will befall all of us."

The chief went to Jangal Bāri but his whole soul yearned towards Sripur, (Ll. 1-52).

(7)

On the eighth day of the waxing moon in the month of Chaitra, the chief ordered his ship to be ready. He took a strong army with him and started for Sripur. He cast anchor on the landing ghat at Sripur and sat on board the ship awaiting the approach of the fair maiden. She came, as expected, for bathing, a short while after. She too was restless and wanted to be at once united with the youth.

The maids—her companions, were with her as usual. A camp of canvas was stretched round a part of the Padmā and therein she sported with her gay friends. Her heart, however, was not in the sport. She only thought, how soon she would meet the lord of her heart. The chief perceived a brilliance through the *Padmā*; it seemed to him like a glow of fire reflected from the canvas and knew that the maiden had entered therein. He leaped out from his ship and catching hold of her from the midst of her attending maids, sprang on board the ship and at once ordered a speedy march homewards. The oarsmen plied the ship with all their might and it flew like a bird on the air.

The message at once reached Kedar Roy, whose sister Ishā Khan had thus carried off. With hundred boats, each carrying a strong army, he pursued the enemy but the *Kosha* of the Khan went with a speed, which could only be compared with that of a bird, and the Raja could not overtake the abductor of his sister. His boats remained two miles behind the "Kosha" of the Moslem Chief. In great despair he called aloud to Ishā Khan and exclaimed, "What city is there that will give you shelter, protecting you from my wrath after such an insult done to my family? If but once I can catch hold of you I will kick your head out and humiliate you like a slave; whether you hide yourself in the depth of water or in the air, I will one day catch you. Even if I cannot do so, my wrath will be visited on your sons; so that any how I must have full retaliation for this wrong. I take this solemn oath in the name of God." With this threat the Raja traced his way back to Sripur and Ishā Khan with his precious booty safely landed at Jangal Bāri. A short time after, he married her. Her Hindu name Subhadrā was changed into Nyāmat Ján, and

the chief became greatly attached to her. So deep was their love that they remained together night and day and never separated from one another. Three years after, she gave birth to a son. In the lap of the mother, the baby looked bright as the moon. It was a thing so beautiful, that words fail to give an idea of its charming appearance. The baby filled its mother's heart with affection and they gave him the name of Adam Khan Mashnad Ali. Three years passed and another son was born to Isha Khan. He was as beautifulas Adam and they gave him the name of Birám. Now listen, oh my audience, to what happened next. (Ll. 1-58.)

(8)

When Adam reached his fifteenth year, Isha Khan Mashnad Ali passed away from this earth. This world is a vain show, my brethren,—none is one's own on this temporary stage. No one will travel with you to that unknown region,—be the person your wife, or son, or your own brother. They will readily take a share of your earnings and enjoy, but none is there who will be your fellow-traveller in the path of eternity. So all is vanity and one born must inevitably be a prey to death.

"Alas ! who could fill up the gap created by the death of Isha Khan at Jangalbari ?" Everybody who heard the news of his death, asked this question to himself. And the news was heard by the people of the neighbouring countries. In course of time Raja Kedar Roy also heard the report of Isha Khan's death. This wicked man thought it to be an opportune moment. He made fourteen of his best-equipped pleasure-boats laden with sweets and delicacies and led them to Jangalbari. He went direct to the palace of Isha Khan

and paid a visit to his sister. The widowed sister was overjoyed at the visit of her brother and gave him a warm welcome. They sat together and passed some hours in pleasant conversation. The Raja, in course of his talk, said to his sister, "Oh my dear sister, you have been very happy, though you gave up your caste. Isha Khan was certainly a more prosperous man than myself. You are besides happy in your two sons, I am right glad to see them. I had a great mind to see Isha Khan up here, but it was not my good fortune to fulfil that wish. I was extremely sorry to hear the news of his death. God has granted me two daughters. I do not find suitable bride-grooms for them. I am much worried over the question of their marriage. Your house is certainly a noble one, and I have come here with great expectation. I am quite willing to marry my daughters to my two nephews, if you would agree to this match. I may, in that case, take my nephews over to Sripur for performing the marriage ceremonies. What do you say, my dear sister, to this proposal of mine ?"

The sister began to tremble in fear as she heard the words of her brother.

"My brother," she thought, "has come here to ruin me. His heart is still beating with a spirit of revenge and he has come with the object of retaliating the wrong done to my father's family. He is trying by his artful words to win my heart ; he will sacrifice my sons at the altar of Goddess Kálī. That assuredly is his object. The two birds of my affectionate heart, he has come to tear off from me." She was seized with great fear and thought within herself as to what means she should adopt to save the children at this crisis. But she hid her fears and said, "I see no objection, dear brother,

to the proposed match. But how, being a Hindu, can you think of marrying your daughters to your nephews?" The Raja said in reply, "Amongst Mahammadans, there can be no objection to marrying cousins. So there is possibly no objection on your side, and I will make matters smooth as far as we are concerned. Don't entertain any doubt on this point."

Then at this critical point, she was at her wit's end to devise a plan as to how to get rid of this enemy of a brother, and slowly collecting herself, she said, "You propose that the marriage should take place at your house, but that is not the custom with this family. My sons cannot go to your house before marriage, which is to be celebrated here." The Raja said in reply, "My mother, dear sister, wants to see your sons. They are her grand-children, I have no objection to the marriage being celebrated in your palace, but before the marriage takes place, it is my mother's wish that she should see your sons. Her bereaved soul will draw a great consolation from seeing the faces of the lovely boys."

The sister, after a moment's pause, replied, "I feel, oh dear brother, the presentiment of some evil in sending my sons to your palace. My heart throbs at the thought of some evil which I cannot fully express, but which, my mind tells me, may happen if they leave are allowed to this city." (Ll. 1-70)

(9)

The Raja understood his sister's mind and taking leave of her came to his boat. He now thought about this matter and sent invitation-letters for dinner at his boat to all people of Jangalbari, high and low. The minister, the high officials, the land-holders, the citizens, the army and the police force were all invited. The great warrior Karimulla was also among them. The

two nephews of course got the most cordial and special invitation.

They all took their repast and returned home after dinner. The wicked Kedar Roy sat with his nephews in the boat and had a pleasant conversation. They were charmed with the affectionate conduct of their uncle and forgot the hour when they should have returned to their palace. Evening passed away, even then the conversation between the uncle and the nephews did not cease. It was now 10 P.M. The nephews became anxious to return home. The wicked Kedar Roy said, "It is not a stranger to whom you have come! Why are you feeling restless? Am I not your nearest relative? Do you really take me for a stranger? What harm if you pass one night with your uncle? Don't be anxious, lads, remain here this night. In the morning you will return to your palace." They were charmed with the show of affection from their uncle and slept on the boat after a lively conversation. When they had fallen into a deep sleep at mid-night, the Captain sailed the boats homeward under the Raja's orders. The sails were all unfurled and aided by the favourable wind and skill of oarsmen, the boats travelled in a day what in ordinary course it would take three days to travel. (Ll. 1-32.)

(10)

In the morning the two brothers Adam and Birám rose from their sleep and asked their uncle as to where the boats were going. "Why not, oh uncle, land us here so that we may go and meet our mother. She is no doubt very anxious for us." The Raja said that the palace of the brothers where their mother lived was not far off. They would very soon reach it. Under such



"Kedar Roy sat with his nephews and had a pleasant conversation." P. 356.

pretexts he took them to Sripur which they reached in two and half days. The boats laid anchor at the landing ghat of the Padmā where the city of the Raja stood. Immediately by his orders the brothers were put under chains. They were imprisoned in a dark room, and the Raja in the presence of his officers abused the brothers in the filthiest language referring to their parents. "You have come here to marry my daughters. I will shew you what sort of marriage I meant"—saying so he ordered the brothers to be laid down with a stone weighing 40 lbs. on the breast of each. They began to cry 'Allah, Allah' in great distress. Their lament would melt a stone. "If our mother get the news of this,"–they said weeping, "she will die of grief. we are like the two ribs of her heart. How can she for one moment feel a sense of relief as our father is dead and she has none to call her own except ourselves." They almost fainted crying helplessly. "Alas," they said, "who is here to feel compassion for us? If brother Karimulla would have been here, with his huge club, he would pursue our wicked uncle and send him to the region of death. Oh God how cruel is thy decree! we are going to die here in this utterly helpless manner!"

Now, my audience, for a moment let me leave the topic of Sripur and revert to an account of the events that took place at Jangalbari. The invited guests, one by one, returned to their house. Niamat Jan, the mother of the princes, anxiously awaited their return in her bed-chamber. But the night passed and it was dawn when still the lads did not return. Her soul, as it were, left the body in great fear. "Where have my two sons gone!" She thought. "Surely Kedar Roy has done some mischief." She called the great warrior Karimulla to her presence and told him that her sons had not

returned after the dinner given by her brother. Karimulla became anxious at the news; he ordered a slave to go to the river-ghat and bring information as to why they did not return in the night. The slave went and found none on the river-bank,—the fields there were deserted and there was no human being to be seen. The princes were not there nor was there any trace of Kedar Roy and his fourteen boats. When this news reached Niamat Jan, she bitterly lamented and was almost mad with grief. Unable to bear the lamentations of the bereaved mother, Karimulla roared like a lion and said, "Do not cry, oh venerable lady, remove all grief from your heart. I take the vow of bringing to you the decapitated head of Kedar Roy. I will restore your sons to you. Do not weep, I take the solemn vow, that so long I cannot bring back the princes, I will not return to the palace."

This is the great warrior Karimulla. No one ever heard that he had been defeated anywhere in any battle. If a thousand men attacked him, all together, with strokes of his huge club he would send them all to the regions of the dead. His stature was tall as it was heavy, so that he looked like a hillock; his colour was deep black and flashes like embers of fire emanated from his eyes, when he got angry; his limbs were like the trunks of a fig tree; on his shoulders he bore a club, twenty maunds in weight. With that club thrown over his right shoulder, the warrior marched in great haste. "Wherever I shall find that wicked Kedar Roy, I will crush him to death like a fly by a stroke of this club"—thus did he muse within himself, as he proceeded on. In three days he reached the city of Sripur. When he heard about the sorrowful condition of the two princes, he turned as one mad. He began to kill and assault any one and every one whom he met. Kedar Roy heard this and

Ishā Khan



"Do not cry, oh venerable lady, I take the vow of bringing to you the head of Kedar Roy." P. 358.

became very sorry at the destruction of his people by the mad giant. He ordered his army to capture him. The whole army surrounded one man. He began to beat and assault them as best as he could—but how could he continue such an unequal struggle for long? When he found himself quite helpless, he hastily fled away to save his life. He came running to the landing ghat of the Padmā but was pursued by Kedar Roy's army. He plunged himself into the waters. The river was full, but he swam across under the waters raising his head only thrice over the river to draw his breath. He thus crossed the Padmā unseen by others. They all concluded that he must have been swallowed by a crocodile. The army returned from the river-ghat.

On the other bank of the river lived a boatman named Sadhan. In the depth of night Karimulla called him out and gave full account of himself. Hearing all from the beginning to the end, the boatman fed the warrior sumptuously. The menu consisted of one maund of *chira*, fifteen seers of sugar, two maunds of curd, with one seer of salt. He exhausted all this and Sadhan with his swift fishing boat, led Karimulla through the Padmā to Jangalbari which they reached in a day. Having come back to his city Karimulla took the whole army of the palace on the Kosha and started for Sripur. It flew like a bird helped by the wind.

Now, let us resume our story of Sripur. The two daughters of Kedar Roy came to know that their cousins of Jangalbari had been brought there on the false pretext of marriage with themselves. They put their two heads together and discussed the matter fully. "These princes," they said," have been given hopes of getting us for their wives. Now it behoves us to accept them as husbands. As our father has pledged his word, if we do not become

their wives, ill will it fare with our parent in the next world. It is our duty to save these youths from danger. My parents may do things on the impulse of anger, but we should take a quiet view of matters and try our best to help the princes." They took rice and other food in golden plates and, when the night was advanced, paid a visit to then in the prison. They said with great tenderness, "Our father has brought you here on the pretext of giving us in marriage to you. You were, no doubt, pleased at the proposal and have come here joyfully. How happy would it be also for us to get you as our husbands. We will try our best to please you by our whole-hearted and life-long devotion. It does not matter what my father will do. Pray, do not take us for your enemies. Whether you marry us or not depends on your will; as for us, we assure you, even though one should cut our throats, we would not agree to seek our bridegrooms elsewhere. We have elected you as our lords and for your sake, dear ones, we are here, prepared to give up our parents."

On hearing this Adam replied, "We will not marry you stealthily, so please go back home. We give you words, we will marry you openly, if Providence grants the day for it. We will take meals prepared by you—but not to-day. Take back the plates full of rice. If God be willing, you will serve us meals in our palace, and we will gladly partake of the same on some future day."

The girls were sad at heart at the words of the brothers and returned to the inner compartments of the palace, in a dejected spirit. This event was like a great fire that overtook the Sripur palace that day and it was not extinitguished till it burnt all happiness of the house, not sparing the life of Kedar Roy himself. (Ll. 1-150.)

(11)

On the tenth day, the 'Kosha' led by Karimulla reached Sripur. He landed there with his army. They raised the cry 'kill,' 'kill' and attacked the palace. Kedar Roy perceived that it would be impossible to make a successful stand against the vast number of enemies assembled there. Finding himself helpless he ordered the princes to be taken to the temple of Kali for sacrifice. Some soldiers hastily took them there at the Raja's order. The daughters of Kedar Roy heard the news from their inner apartments and made constant enquiries as to what was happening but could not obtain any further news. They became maddened with grief. Each of the princesses took a sword in her hand and paid a visit to the temple. They saw the young lads tied to the altar—and a man whetting his weapon to give the final stroke. One of the girls forthwith ran and with a stroke of her sword killed the man. They did not stop there, but killed another servant of the temple, so that all the people fled from there. They thus saved the life of the brothers, and stood in the gate-way ready with their swords. Whoever tried to enter the gate with the object of sacrificing the princes at the altar, was killed by the sisters in the same way. The army of Jangalbari in the meantime surrounded the city of Sripur and set fire to the houses of the citizens. The golden city was destroyed in this way. Men and women fled in all directions in precipitous haste, and many were killed.

And now hear what happened to the wicked Kedar Roy next. He fled with his life, and Karimulla with his utmost vigilance could not find out the place where he had hidden himself. The warrior resolved to kill him, "for," he thought, "if he be spared, he may form some

plot in future to endanger us all. I will kill him wherever he may have hidden himself, and I will not return home until I have taken his life."

Now the daughters of Kedar Roy with the princes came where Karimulla was; and they all were highly rejoiced at the sight. The daughters said, "It will not be safe, Oh Karim, to spare the enemy. Even if he be a saint he must be killed. If he be spared none of us will be safe. We know where he is. We will give you the information. You are to go there and kill him with your own hands. When attacked by the enemy, he seldom stays at his palace. In the forests of Asua, there is a nice building under-ground. The surface of it is covered by a thick jungle; it is connected with the river by a tunnel and thither does he retire at the hour of danger. The house has nine gate-ways and a big hall, and there he reposes on a couch. Karim was right glad at the news and forthwith went to meet the enemy. Asua was five *Rashis* from Sripur. The place was covered with an avenue of tamarind trees. On the southern side of the forest, Karimulla discovered the mouth of the tunnel and straightway he entered it and found nine gate-ways which he crossed one by one till he reached the Raja's hall where he was found sleeping with a feeling of absolute security. Karimulla, as soon as he saw him, roared like a lion. The Raja's sleep was gone and he held fast a sword that lay near him. But before he could aim a stroke with it, Karimulla smashed his head with the huge club that he carried with him. Then with the sword he cut off his head, and carrying it in his hand, came back to Sripur. His army greatly rejoiced at this victory. Karimulla next started for Jangalbari and arriving there, made preparations for the marriage of the brothers. The Moulvi of the Court

fixed an auspicious day during the period of the waxing moon. The city of Jangalbari was beautifully decorated, and it smiled like a second heaven. Bonfires were lighted and guns were fired. Thousands of respectable men assembled. On the marriage day, the brides and bride-grooms wore bridal costumes and ornaments after bath. The brides wore gorgeous *sadis* brought from Persia. Their dress was so rich and ornaments so beautiful that even the fairies could not cope with them. Adam and Bairam wore valuable Egyptian coats, and caps brought from Arabia. Their shoes were made at Persia. Kasturi, kumkum, attar and other perfumes were sprinkled over their persons. When after robing, they met their consorts, the whole city, as it were, shone with their beauty. Now came the pleader (উকীল) and asked the daughters if they willingly chose Adam and Bairam as their bride-grooms. The princesses assented to the marriage. Then Adam and Bairam also agreed to it. Thus the memorable marriage came to an end and a great feast followed worthy of the occasion. (Ll. 1-104.)

Another Short History of Isha Khan.

The Dewans of Jangalbari had a historical account of their family written by competent persons, which was some years ago published from Haibatnagar. The materials of this history were collected from the papers preserved in the archives of the Dewan family and were also drawn freely from the Aini-Akbari, the Akbarnama, Syer-ul-Mutakherin, Alumni and the historical treatises written by Marshman and other European writers. A large mass of material was also collected from the traditions current in the country and the compilers used their discretion in dealing with popular versions of the accounts of the administration of the Dewans, by rejecting such elements in them as were untrustworthy or could not be substantiated by other evidences. This treatise is, by no means, to be called a perfect or complete one as the writers could not lay hold upon the ancestry and other particulars about a considerable number of families who still live in Mymensingh and call themselves scions of the Dewan family. The main difficulty arises from the fact that along with the genuine Dewan families, numerous families have sprung up recognised as Dewans but whose claims to legitemacy are of a doubtful character. Some of the old Dewans used to fill their harems with fair-looking Hindu women carried by force. The children born of these women were called Dewans by courtesy. And in many cases they also inherited some property of the Dewans.

The historical treatise referred to above was undertaken, at the instance of Dr. James Wise, late Civil

Surgeon of Dacca, by Dewan Sovandád Khán. The Dewan appointed his chief officer Munshi Raj Chandra Ghose to collect information for the purpose. He was helped by late Muhammad Idris, the then manager of the State of Haibatnagar in collecting these materials. But as Dewan Sovandád Khán had died a short while after, the undertaking could not proceed and was inpeded for some time. But luckily Dewan Ajimdád Khán, the brother of the deceased Dewan, interested himself in the work and encouraged Munshi Raj Chandra Ghose in resuming his task. This gentleman in co-operation with one Kalikumar Chakravarty, the then Head Pundit of the Jangalbari School, compiled the historical treatise tracing it from the founder of the family. The Head Pundit had lived in that part of the country for twenty-one years and succeeded in collecting a large amount of historical information from various sources. The history of the Dewan family covers a period of nearly four hundred years and as no systematic account was preserved of them, the authors often found historical information scanty and had to depend on traditions current in the countryside. They would gladly wait for getting an opportunity to obtain fuller materials; but the pressing requests from Mr. Lowes, Commissioner of the Dacca Division, and Mr. R. C. Dutt, Magistrate of Mymensingh, made it necessary to publish the history hurridly and in a somewhat imperfect shape.

This book is divided into eleven chapters. Unfortunately, owing to the whims of one of the Dewans, many important documents of the family were destroyed. Dewan Haibat Khan, fourth in descent from Ishā Khan, separated himself from the main family and founded a town called Haibatnagar, six miles to the west of Jangalbari. Dewan Shaha Neoaj, who was fifth in descent from

Dewan Haibat and died in 1247 B. E., is said to have done a very queer and whimsical thing. It is said that he, opened one day, an old chest containing the Sanadas granted to the family by the Delhi Emperors and some other valuable State-papers and letters. Looking at these he exclaimed, "We are no longer what we were. These only serve to make us conceited." And he threw them into the Narshindha.

I give below a short summary of the history of the Dewan family as given in the treatise.

The Eastern part of Mymensigh is popularly known as Haibatnagar-Jangalbari. This includes, amongst others, the Perganas of Hajradi, Husain Sahi, and Nashir-u-jiral. Jangalbari proper, the site of the Dewans, was originally comprised within the village Kadir-jangal and covered a space of 50 bighas only. The people of the surrounding villages, however, to the extent of hundred miles on all sides, still call themselves, when they visit other countries, as inhabitants of Jangalbari."

There are two ports in this part of the country, *viz.*, Kishoreganj and Karimganj. From these ports are exported every year a large quantity of very fine species of rice, jute, sugar, molasses, clarified butter, mats and other articles to Narayanganj, Dacca and other western districts. This country produces fine clothes of a variety of textures manufactured at Sharfarali, Jangalkhasa Salman, and Abruagunj, Half a century ago, Jangalbari was in utter darkness,—ignorance and superstition reigning supreme in it. Shortly after the creation of Kishoreganj as a Sub-divisional headquarters, a middle vernacular school was established there mainly through the efforts of Babu Nandalal Bose, Munsiff, and was called Haibatnagar Minor School. The establishment of

a Brahmo Samaj was the next step towards the advancement of the people and the late illustrious Deputy Magistrate Rai Ram Sankar Sen Bahadur took a lively interest in the cause of local education and helped in the foundation of other schools. There are two high schools, one at Haibatnagar and another at Bajitpur; ten or twelve middle vernacular schools have since come into existence at Jangalbari and neighbouring villages.

Masnadāli.

Kālidās Singh Gajdāni, a Kshatriya by caste, became convert to Islam and assumed the title of Soleman Khan. The family originally came from a place called Baishwara in Oudh. Before he became the Sultan of Bengal he was an orthodox Hindu and used to give away a golden elephant to the Brahmins every day. Kālidās thus earned the name of Gajdāni—the giver of elephants. Kālidās was the Prime Minister of Bāhādur Shāh, the ruler of Bengal who died in 1570 A.D. His younger brother, Jelaluddin (popularly called Jainuddin), succeeded him. He had three daughters and a little son. The eldest of these daughters was married to Syed Ibrāhim ol-olelmā and the second to the illustrious (?) Kālāpāhār.

Syed Ibrāhim was known for his high character and piety and Kālidās Gajdāni often discussed religious matters with him. He was gradually convinced of the superiority of Islam and finally gave up his faith in Hinduism sometime between 1561 and 1565. The little son, Jelal, had died when a mere child and Kālidās Gajdāni who had married his third daughter and adopted the name of Soleman Khan now succeeded to the throne of Gour. He ingratiated himself into the confidence of the Emperor Akbar by offering him valuable presents and

considerably increased his kingdom which now comprised Bengal, Behar, Orissa and portions of Allahabad.

Soloman Khan died about the year 1571 leaving two sons, Dewan Ismail Khan, popularly known as Daud Khan, and Dewan Ishā Khan.

Soloman had also a daughter named Shahen Shā. She was married to Tajiuddin Gada, a remote descendant of the illustrious king Haroun-al-rachid.

Dewan Ismāil, on ascending the throne, stopped paying revenue to the Emperor of Delhi. A battle ensued in 1575 when he was killed. His brother Ishā Khan succeeded him, but following the example of his elder brother, he also quarrelled with the Delhi emperor. A great battle took place in which Ishā Khan was defeated by the eminent general of the Mogul army—Shahabaj Khan. Ishā Khan, after his defeat, fled to Chittagong. The news of the victory of the Mogul army was communicated to Akbar by Munshi Abul Fajal. On page 119 of the treatise Almuni, written in Persian, the very words of Akbar expressing his delight at the event are quoted. They run thus—" A highly gratifying news has been received from Bengal. By the grace of God, Shahabaj Khan, our general, has conquered the vast tract of land from Ghorāghāt to Sāgar. Ishā Khan, who headed the rebels, has fled towards Sāgar after his defeat."

Dewan Ishā Khan after his defeat first paid a visit to Chittagong and then came to Jangalbari. At that time the place was an impenetrable jungle—infested with wild beasts. Hence Ishā Khan gave it the name of Jangalbari or the Wood-land Mansion. The inhabitants of the place generally belonged to the Koch tribe. Here stood the beautiful palace of Laksman Singh—the Raja of the tribe—surrounded by a ditch, 100 yds. in breadth. On the south a road, 15 yds. in

breadth, ran leading to the palace. Ishā Khan with his army entered the Rājā's house with the object of killing him and made a great search to find him out. But the Rājā had made his retreat by a sub-terranean tunnel, made of bricks, which lay beneath the eastern part of the ditch.

Traces of the road and the ditch, with an area of 50 bighas of land containing debris of the ruined palace, are still to be seen.

Ishā Khan firmly planting himself at Jangalbari now made deliberate plans for extending his territories. He built forts at each of the following places :—Murapara in the district of Dacca, Dewanbag and Hajiganj (near Murapara), Egarasindur on the Brahmaputra, Sherpur, *Dasa Kahania* and Rangamati. Akbar in the meantime heard of Isha Khan's attempts to assert his independence and sent his famous commandar Mansingh to punish the rebel. Mansingh pitched his tent at Demrā in the district of Dacca, and he had a large tank dug in that place, which was filled with water from all the famous Indian shrines. He gave it the name of Ganga-sagar. The neighbouring place he called by the name of Rájárbág or 'the garden of the Raja.' Up to now the place is considered sacred, and hundreds of pilgrims visit it on the eighth day of the waxing moon during the *Báruni* festivities, and a large fair sits there on the occasion.

After Mansingh had arrived at Demra, he fought a battle with Isha Khan near the fort of Dewanbag. The latter was defeated and retired to the fort of Egarasindur. Here a most sanguinary battle took place lasting for three consecutive days, in which considerable armies on both the sides were destroyed. This made both parties willing to settle matters by a duel fight. When according to mutual agreement, Isha Khan came out on his war-horse challenging Mansingh, the latter instead of

appearing himself in the field took to the device of sending his son-in-law who accepted the challenge.

The son-in-law was a good warrior but though he fought well for a long while, he could not maintain his position up to the end. He fell struck by the sword of the Dewan. The soldiers of Isha Khan thought that it was Mansingh who had been killed and raised the cry of victory. Mansingh in wounded pride and grieved at the death of his son-in-law, now appeared in the field, "angry as a serpent struck on the head by a club." The two warriors fought with a skill which raised a feeling of wonder among the spectators, and for a long time no one could foresee who the victor would be. In the evening the sword of Mansingh broke, struck by that of Isha Khan.

Isha Khan requested the Raja to take another sword, but the Raja without giving a reply came down from his horse. Isha Khan thought that the Raja wished to fight the duel by wrestling. So he too left his weapons and horse, and stood facing him. The Raja at this stage, expressed his wish to desist from the fight altogether and extended his right hand to Isha Khan as a sign of friendship. Isha Khan shook hands with him in joy. There was for some time great rejoicings in the camps. Now, the time came for parting. The wife of Mansingh interviewed Isha Khan privately and said, "If you do not accompany us to Delhi, a great danger will befall us, for, the order upon my husband is very severe. He must take you with him to Delhi; otherwise the punishment of death would be visited on him. Now if you sincerely wish that I should not be made a widow, kindly accompany us to Delhi." The importunate tears of his friend's wife moved Isha Khan whose nature was generous and

he forthwith agreed to go to Delhi in Mansingh's camp. On his arrival at the great city of the empire Isha Khan was unscrupulously thrown into prison.

A short while after, through the intervention of Mansingh and his sister—the queen of Akbar, Isha Khan was released from the prison. When the Emperor heard from Mansingh the account of Isha Khan as to how bravely he had fought and how nobly he volunteered to be taken to Delhi, he was exceedingly pleased and gave him a seat on his right in the court as a mark of special honour. He conferred on Isha Khan the title of Masnadali and the grant of 24 Parganas as a rent-free gift. He moreover placed four Gajis, four Asahebs and four Majlishis under him and made him the head of these twelve sub-lords. The descendants of Isha Khan still bear the proud title of Masnadali.

With these new honours and title Isha Khan returned to Jangalbari. The four Asahebs were given lands at Tārāp and other villages of Sylhet where they settled. The Majlishis settled at Khaliajuri in Pargana Nasir-u-*jiral* (Jian), the Gazis settled in Parganas of Bhowal and Sherpur where their descendants are living up to now. The descendants of the four Majlishis are to be found even now at Panch Kahaniá and Fatepur in Pargana Nasir-u-Jiral. The ruins of the famous palatial buildings of Majlish Jalal are still to be seen at Rowail—the native villlage of the chief—with their fine crystal pillars and artistic designs carved on the walls.

Ishā Khan, the Lord of 24 Parganas, had now a firm footing at Jangal Bāri. He married his cousin—a daughter of Syed Ibrahim—Malik-ul-ulma. Ishā Khan got two sons by her, Dewan Musha Khan and Dewan Mahammad Khan. Ishā Khan died in advanced years. His grave is still to be seen at Baktiārpur in Pargana Bhowal.

The Names of the 24 Parganas.

(1) Atia, (2) Kagmari, (3) Barabaju, (4) Sherpur, (5) Jayan Shahi, (6) Alapsing, (7) Mymensingh, (8) Jafarshah, (9) Nasir-u-jiral, (10) Khaliajury, (11) Gangamandal, (12) Paitkura, (13) Bardakhat, (14) Swarnagram, (15) Baradakhat mándrá, (16) Husainsahi, (17) Bhowal, (18) Maheswardi, (19) Katrar, (20) Kurikhai, (21) Jour Husainpur, (22) Singdha, (23) Darjibaju, (24) Hajradi.

The Genealogical Tree of the Dewan Family.

Raja Dhanapati Singh of Baishwara in Oudh

Raja Bhagirath Singh.

1. Kali Das Gazdani (Solomon Khan)

2. Daud Khan

2. Isha Khan

3. Musha Khan

4. Mosum Khan

5. Manwar Khan

6. Sharif Khan

6. Mahabat Khan

7 Asalat Khan

7. Molaim Khan

6. Adam Khan (Manai Khan)

7. Eoz Mahamood (D. 1241 B.E.)

7. Multaf Khan

8. Ajjor Khan

11. Khoda Newaz Khan (D. 1266 B.E.) at Shachi Pan Daripa Dacca

12. Rahim Newaz Khan

3. Mahamad Khan

4. Eoz Mamood Khan (1059-1078. B.E.)

5. Hayat Khan

6. Haybat Khan

7. Abdulla Khan

8. Mamood Khan

9. Jolkaran Khan

10. Shaha Newaz Khan (D. 1247. B.E.

11. Nabi Newaz

12. Elaha Newaz Khan (D. 1279 B.E.) (1872 A.D.)

I shall here jot down a few notes in connection with some of the Dewans.

1. There are two grants of Shah Jahan written in brilliant golden letters to Dewan Eoz Mahamad Khan preserved by his descendants.

2. Dewan Haybat Khan founded a town called Haibat-Nagar six miles to the west of Jangal Bāri.

3. Reference has already been made as to how Dewan Shaha Newaz Khan destroyed some of the important documents of the Dewan family.

4. Dewan Khoda Newaz had for a time turned a Fakir and then returned to resume his duties as a worldly man.

5. Dewan Ibrahim Khan spent Rs. 50,000 in getting the whole Epic of Mahabharat recited and explained by competent pundits to the people of Mymensingh.

6. Dewan Rahim Dād Khan, at whose order, the historical treatise about the Dewan family first began to be written was a person of rare talents, whose taste and proficiency in Arts are still admired. He could make fine figures with ivory and prepared many beautiful musical instruments such as *Setar*, *Bin*, *Echraj* with his own hands, himself being a master of Indian musics. He was an expert calligraphist, and specimens of his skill are still preserved in various parts of Mymensingh.

The last scion of this distinguished Dewan Family is Dewan Azim Dād Khan, a brother of Dewan Rahim Dād Khan. He is a young man of great promise and noble character.

The Dewans in the past were regarded as heads of both Hindu and Mahomedan Communities of Eastern Mymensingh. Without their permission no religious festivity such as the Dol or the Durgotshab could be performed in Hindu homes. They even ruled over the

tastes and fashions of the people. For using particular ornaments, dress and costumes, their permission was necessary. Up to now the lower class of people in the district seek the permission of the Dewans for building certain kinds of houses.

SURAT JAMAL AND ADHUA.

PREFACE.

The poet Faizu Fakir, who describes himself "blind from birth", is the author of this ballad. We find his name in the colophon at the end of some of the cantos; it occurs altogether five times. Beyond telling us that he had no father, no mother and no brother, he does not give us any further account of himself. And Chandrakumar Babu has not been able to illuminate us any more on the life of the poet. Getting information about this ballad Babu Chandrakumar left his native village of Aithor in the district of Mymensing on the 26th of Chaitra, 1327 B.E., and reached Baniachang in Sylhet about the first week of the next month. He stayed at Roybagan (Aṭharabari P.O.) at the *Gadi* of one Narayan Babu and collected this ballad from three different rhapsodists who were quite innocent of any knowledge of letters.

The Dewans of Baniachang, like those of Jangalbari, were originally Hindus. In he fourteenth century Dewan Govinda Khan, the Brahmin Raja of the place, turned a Mahomedan convert and assumed the name of Habib Khan. Baniachang is one of the largest,—if not the largest village in the district of Sylhet. It has still a population of thirty thousand. Habib Khan was not only the lord of the place but acquired possession of the neighbouring kingdom of Laur, and of altogether 24 Parganas of the district. Baniachang is situated in 24° 31′N. and 91° 20′E. In the jungles of Laur there are still to be seen the ruins of a fort known as "Baniachang Habeli," attesting to the power once exercised by

the Dewans of Baniachang over Laur. The line of the Dewans still continues in shrivelled and decayed glory, and Dewan Ajem Raja, who is living, is its present representative.

The ballad relates a story about this Dewan family. I could not get the names of Alal Khan, Dulal Khan and Jamal Khan in the genealogy of the Dewans. One Jamal Khan's name I find as 5th in descent from Habib Khan—The famous convert to Islam. But the father of this Jamal Khan in the genealogy is Ahamad Khan and not Alal Khan as found in the ballad. So the two Jamal Khans do not seem to be identical persons. The Dewans, however, had their pet names by which they were more familiarly known in the country, and the poet, it is quite possible, might have used these rather than the more dignified names of the chiefs to be found in documentary writings.

I sought the help of my friend Babu Achyutcharan Chaudhuri of Maina, Kanaibazar, Sylhet, for the solution of this problem. He is now the greatest living authority on all questions regarding the old history of Sylhet.

I shall quote here a portion from his letter dated the 1st of Agrahayana, 1329 B.E., dealing with my queries at some length.

"What will you do with Alal and Dulal of Baniachang? My work on the history of Sylhet has recently been published in four volumes, complete in two thousand pages. There is an account of Baniachang in this work. But the names of Alal and Dulal do not occur in the genealogy of the Dewans. The descendants of the Dewans cannot give any information on the point. It is besides not unlikely that these are Hindu names adopted by the Moslem Dewans. In the countryside they still call a child spoilt by indulgence as

"Alaler Gharer Dulal." It is quite likely that the two Dewans in question had enjoyed a good deal of indulgence and favour of their parents and were hence popularly called by these names. I am inclined to think that the Dewans, known as Jamal Khan and Kamal Khan, might have been popularly called by the names of Alal and Dulal. In the time of the old Dewans, instances of pet names being used by the people are not wanting. We have got a document, dated 1749 A.D., in which a Dewan of the name of Adam Khan is mentioned, but in the genealogy no such name of a Dewan is found. In the period referred to, we find two Dewans living. They were Ahmed Khan and Mahmud Khan. There can be no doubt that the pet name of this Ahmed Khan was Adam. There is one incidental proof leading to the conjecture that Jamal Khan and Kamal Khan might have been popularly known as Alal and Dulal.

A tradition exists here that the two Dewans had contracted a great friendship with a Raja of Dakshinbhag named Dubaraja. The name Dakshinbhag originated about this time. It is a station on the A. B. Railway and is only thirteen miles from Sylhet.[1] Though Dubaraja's name is now forgotten, yet some historical facts relating to this Raja were once known in the countryside and thes refer to a period about 200 years ago. The origin of the name Dakshinbhag is associated with some social incidents which are of a considerable historical interest.

"Dubaraja is not an unfamiliar name in Sylhet. One of the Vaisnava poets of Sylhet is known by this name. He composed a poem called "Nimai Sanyas" 200 years ago. It is a fountain of devotional feelings and pathos. The poem treats of a visit of Chaitanya's

[1] It is about 36 miles from Badarpur, 216 miles from the western-most point of the railway-line, and 26 miles west of Karimganj.

parents to Sylhet before he was born. I got a MS. of this poem 12 years ago. It is still unpublished. This poet Dubaraja was a Vaisnava saint. It may be that the saintliness of his character attracted the admiring love of the Dewans Kamal Khan and Jamal Khan. There is an agreement in the point of time which leads to the conjecture that Alal Khan and Dulal Khan you speak of were probably identical with the Dewans Kamal Khan and Jamal Khan respectively.

"Sylhet was at one time famous for the ballads and songs of the *Bhats*. The fame of the *Bhats* of Baniachang particularly had spread far and wide. The songs of Makaranda, the prince of these Bhat-poets of Baniachang, are still on the lips of many, and are justly admired.

"Have you got any ballad in which there is a referrence to the friendship of the Dewans Alal and Dulal with Dubaraja? If you have got any, please do not doubt the historical value of such a ballad. Many important and historical events of our country lie hidden in the ballads of these unassuming country-poets, mostly unlettered and unknown to outside fame." (*Translated from Bengali.*)

My friend Mr. Achyuta Charan Chaudhuri Tattvanidhi has yet had no knowledge of this ballad. Without entering into the details of the historical questions involved, I quite agree with my friend's views expressed in the last para of the above extract. Stirring historical events often moved these "inglorious Miltons" of the countryside to compose ballads of this type. They gave the popular versions of the events which, though sometimes marked with a crude humour, are often more reliable than the records of scholarly historians, generally biased by party-feelings and arixous for the favour of their patrous.